

Marriage as Insurance: Household Responses to Immigration Policy Uncertainty

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Abstract

This paper examines whether marriage serves as a strategic response to immigration policy uncertainty. Using ACS data from 2008 to 2019 and a difference-in-differences design, we study transitions into marriage among cohabiting binational couples following the shift in policy expectations during the 2016 presidential campaign and the subsequent tightening of enforcement in 2017. Immigration policy uncertainty increased marriage rates by approximately 1.9 percentage points — a 10 percent increase relative to pre-treatment levels, rising to 15 percent among already-cohabiting couples. The response anticipates formal enforcement, is concentrated among long-established immigrants, targeted nationalities, lower-educated households, and couples with children, consistent with marriage functioning as legal and economic insurance against deportation risk.

Keywords: Marriage, Immigration Policy, Household Responses

JEL Codes: J12, J15, J61

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1. Introduction

Marriage is typically viewed as a social and economic institution shaped by preferences, norms, matching considerations, and life-cycle factors (Becker, 1973; Stevenson and Wolfers, 2007). Yet in environments of legal uncertainty, it may also serve as a form of insurance. This paper studies whether binational couples, in which one member is a US citizen and the other is not, use marriage strategically to mitigate heightened immigration policy risk during the 2016 U.S. presidential campaign and its aftermath.

For couples with a noncitizen member, the prospect of intensified deportations and stricter enforcement increases the risk of family separation (Amuedo-Dorantes and Arenas-Arroyo, 2019). The 2016 presidential campaign marked a sharp shift in immigration policy expectations and immigration-related fears in the United States (Appendix Figure A.1).¹ Those expectations were likely reinforced once the new administration took office in January 2017 and reinstated the Secure Communities deportation program nationwide.

This shift in the policy environment may have changed the value of formalizing the union for couples with a non-citizen member, as deportation or forced migration can imply the loss and disruption of investments in work, educational progress, household formation, and social networks (Alsan and Yang, 2024; East and Velásquez, 2024; Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman, 2022). We examine whether cohabiting binational couples responded by transitioning into marriage at higher rates, and whether this response was stronger among couples facing greater exposure to deportation risk or higher potential costs.

By 2015, immigration enforcement was not new. Secure Communities had expanded nationwide between 2008 and 2014 (Cox and Miles, 2013) and was subsequently scaled back. What changed in 2015 was the salience and tone of the public debate. Immigration became central to the presidential campaign, with repeated promises of mass deportations, stricter

¹Immigration uncertainty started escalating in the third quarter of 2015, after the Trump campaign announcement and no accompanying increase in general economic policy uncertainty is registered for the same period.

border enforcement, and restrictions targeting specific nationalities. As Donald Trump secured the Republican nomination in mid-2016 and won the general election in November 2016, these campaign promises increasingly shaped expectations about future enforcement (Lopez et al., 2018). Upon taking office in January 2017, the administration reinstated Secure Communities nationwide and introduced additional measures aimed at tightening immigration control. Together, these developments generated a period of heightened uncertainty for immigrant households.

We exploit the shift in immigration policy expectations that emerged in mid-2015, together with the subsequent tightening of enforcement in 2017, as a source of variation in perceived deportation risk. We implement a difference-in-differences design comparing cohabiting binational couples —defined as unions between a U.S. citizen and a noncitizen— to homogeneous citizen couples in which both are U.S. citizens, whose legal status is not directly affected by immigration enforcement. This comparison captures differential exposure to immigration-related uncertainty while accounting for common time trends in marriage behavior.

To examine the timing of responses and assess the plausibility of parallel trends, we implement an event-study framework. We then explore whether the observed responses are linked to deliberate protection strategies taken by pre-existing couples or, instead, with new household formations. In additional analyses, we explore heterogeneity by the immigrant profile and by geographic variations in the level of potential exposure. The exercise tests whether households with greater chances of being targeted by enforcement, or facing a larger potential cost, respond more intensively by transitioning into marriage.²

The analysis uses data from the American Community Survey (ACS) from 2008 to 2019. We identify cohabiting couples within households and construct an annual indicator for

²The expected cost of the policy for the couple, or its perceived risk, is given by the subjective probability assigned to the enforcement policy weighted by the potential consequences of deportation and household separation. As discussed earlier, the former one could be decomposed into probability of the policy being implemented, depending on the likelihood of Trump winning the presidential election, and, conditional on implementation, the individual-level probability of being reached by enforcement measures.

transitions into marriage among previously unmarried couples. The unit of analysis is the couple-year. Because binational couples represent a relatively small share of the sample, we complement the cross-sectional analysis with a short retrospective pseudo-panel. Using retrospective information on year of marriage and year of naturalization, we reconstruct marriage and citizenship status up to two years prior to the survey year, under the assumption that the couple was already cohabiting during that period. Both approaches yield similar results.

We merge the ACS with information on sanctuary jurisdictions and 2016 primary election results at the PUMA level. These data allow us to examine cross-sectional variation in local exposure to immigration risk, proxied by sanctuary status as of 2015, and by local variation in the perceived competitiveness of Trump as an electoral candidate and therefore in the likelihood that stricter immigration policies would be implemented.

We find that immigration policy uncertainty increased marriage rates among binational couples by approximately 1.89 percentage points in the preferred specification, corresponding to nearly a 10 percent increase relative to the pre-treatment mean. The effect is robust to extensive individual and household controls, state-level macroeconomic conditions, controls for DACA eligibility, and unauthorized status. Event-study estimates show no evidence of differential pre-trends and indicate that the response emerges in 2016, prior to the formal reinstatement of Secure Communities, consistent with changes in immigration policy expectations and perceived risk.

The response is concentrated among already cohabiting couples, and is absent among newly formed households. In addition, the effect is driven by couples in which the immigrant member has been living in the United States for ten years or longer, consistent with marriage operating as a form of insurance for established immigrants.

Effects are stronger among unauthorized immigrants, individuals from nationalities prominently targeted in the political debate, and couples with lower or middle levels of education. These patterns are consistent with marriage functioning as a protective response among

households facing greater exposure to deportation risk.

Moreover, in areas where the Trump electoral signal was stronger and more credible in 2016, measured by primary election outcomes in that year, couples responded more strongly, particularly couples with at least one child under 16 in the household. In contrast, the estimated effect does not vary systematically with sanctuary city status, where, in fact, cohabiting couples were more likely to get married, suggesting that policy uncertainty played a relevant role in the increase in marriage.

There is a large body of literature that examines the effects of immigration enforcement in the United States on economic and social outcomes, including labor market performance (Amuedo-Dorantes and Bansak, 2012; East et al., 2023; Wang, 2019), mobility (Watson, 2013), participation in social programs (Alsan and Yang, 2024), local crime (Freedman et al., 2018; Miles and Cox, 2014), mental health (Wang and Kaushal, 2019) and children’s education and well-being (Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez, 2015; Amuedo-Dorantes et al., 2018). We show that immigration policy uncertainty reshapes marriage decisions as a strategic response to mitigate deportation risk.

Prior work has shown that policies granting legal status can shape incentives for intermarriage. Kelly (2010) found that both marriage rates and applications for Lawful Permanent Resident status increased following the Legal Immigration and Family Equity Act of 2000, which temporarily allowed undocumented immigrants to apply for legal status adjustments. Redpath (2024) shows that spousal visa access increases mixed-citizenship same-sex marriages. Focusing on the European Union, Azzolini and Guetto (2017); Adda et al. (2025) show that expanded access to EU citizenship reduced intermarriage and increased separation among mixed couples in Italy.

A growing strand of research examines how enforcement policies affect marriage patterns. Wang and Wang (2012) found that Hispanic immigrants became more likely to marry natives after the tighter immigration controls in response to the terrorist attacks. Bansak and Pearlman (2022) find that increased deportations altered marriage composition for immi-

grant women in US but had no impact on marriage to native-born men. [Amuedo-Dorantes et al. \(2020\)](#) show that tighter enforcement from 2005 through 2017 raises the intermarriage propensity of Mexican non-citizens, particularly the low-skilled. Crucially, the effect is not driven by increases in the marriage rate, but rather by increases in the intermarriage rate among those married, a result that points to a different mechanism from the one documented in our study. Their findings highlight changes in the type of spouse married, as an important margin through which immigration enforcement reshapes family formation decisions.

Previous work has also documented the effect of programs granting temporary protection. [Gihleb et al. \(2023\)](#) show that DACA eligibility altered household arrangements but did not detect effects on marriage. By comparing intermarriage changes for DACA-eligible and DACA-ineligible non-citizens, [Amuedo-Dorantes and Wang \(2025\)](#) demonstrate that the threat of DACA’s termination increased intermarriage among eligible undocumented immigrants. These findings shed light on how uncertainty regarding the program shaped marriage decisions among DACA-eligible immigrants.

Our paper contributes to this literature in two important ways. First, rather than studying partner choice or couple formation by looking at the stock of marriages at each point in time, we examine marriage transitions among already cohabiting couples. By comparing unmarried binational and homogeneous unions at the couple level, our outcome captures the formalization of existing unions, allowing us to isolate the marriage decision from changes in partner selection, matching patterns, or divorce behavior.

Second, whereas previous studies primarily focus on realized enforcement intensity, changes in legal status eligibility, or specific immigration programs, our setting captures a broader shift in immigration-related uncertainty associated with the 2016 electoral campaign and the subsequent tightening of enforcement. This allows us to assess whether couples responded not only to *realized* policy changes but also to heightened *perceived* deportation risk, including anticipatory responses that emerged before enforcement changes were fully implemented. Moreover, because this political and institutional shock was not tied to narrowly defined eligi-

bility criteria, our setting allows us to examine household responses across a broader segment of the immigrant population, beyond the scope of a single immigration program or specific immigrant subgroup.

This paper also contributes to the policy debate, showing that marriage may operate as a strategic institutional response to immigration policy uncertainty. Formalizing the union through marriage may provide protection against perceived deportation risk and help preserve household-specific investments for couples, especially for those engaged in long-term relationships. In this sense, immigration policy uncertainty may generate broader and unintended consequences, affecting not only migration and labor market outcomes, but also family formation decisions through reactive and anticipatory responses.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the institutional background and the evolution of immigration enforcement during the 2016 election cycle. Section 3 introduces the data and sample construction. Section 4 presents the empirical strategy. Section 5 reports the main results and event-study evidence. Section 6 examines whether the observed marriage responses are consistent with an insurance mechanism within existing unions rather than with new patterns of household formation. Section 7 examines the heterogeneous effect by immigrant profile, and Section 8 analyzes differential responses by geographic exposure. Section 9 concludes.

2. Policy Background

On June 16, 2015, Donald Trump announced his candidacy for President of the United States. In a 47-minute announcement speech, immigration was introduced within the first minutes and remained a central theme throughout. The speech framed immigration as associated with crime and economic competition, and singled out particular immigrant groups: "*(...) They're sending people that have lots of problems, and they're bringing those problems with us. They're bringing drugs. They're bringing crime. (...) It's coming from more than Mexico. It's coming from all over South and Latin America, and it's coming probably—*

probably— from the Middle East" ([Time Magazine](#)).

During the inaugural speech and in following public presentations Trump emphasized proposals such as mass deportations and stricter border enforcement. Immigration policy subsequently became one of the defining issues of the 2016 electoral cycle, increasing the salience of enforcement and deportation in public debate.

As the campaign progressed and Trump secured the Republican nomination in July 2016, the likelihood that these proposals could translate into policy increased. His victory in the general election in November 2016 further reinforced expectations of a shift toward stricter immigration enforcement. For immigrant households this period marked a substantial increase in perceived deportation risk and uncertainty regarding future legal status ([EPU; Lopez et al. 2018](#))

These expectations were rapidly followed by concrete policy actions. On January 25, 2017, shortly after taking office, President Trump signed Executive Order 13768 (“Enhancing Public Safety in the Interior of the United States”), which reinstated the Secure Communities (SC) program. Unlike its initial rollout between 2008 and 2013, which expanded gradually across jurisdictions ([Cox and Miles, 2013](#)), the 2017 reinstatement was implemented nationwide and immediately reactivated cooperation between local law enforcement and federal immigration authorities. This shift substantially expanded the scope of interior enforcement.

Two days later, on 27 January 2017, the administration issued Executive Order 13769, commonly referred to as the “travel ban,” which suspended entry into the United States for nationals of several predominantly Muslim countries (initially Iran, Iraq, Libya, Somalia, Sudan, Syria, and Yemen) and temporarily halted the refugee admission program. Although the order was subsequently revised and subject to litigation, later versions maintained restrictions on multiple countries and expanded the list of affected nationalities. These measures reinforced the perception that specific immigrant groups were being directly targeted by federal immigration policy.

Then in September 2017, the administration announced its intention to terminate the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) program, which had provided temporary protection from deportation and work authorization to eligible undocumented immigrants. Although federal court rulings in 2018 required the program to continue accepting renewals, the attempted rescission introduced significant uncertainty for beneficiaries. DACA remained active—at least for renewals—throughout the period covered in our analysis (through 2019), but its future legal status remained contested.

For the purposes of this paper, this period is characterized by two related developments: a sharp shift in immigration policy expectations beginning in mid-2015, and the subsequent implementation of stricter enforcement measures in early 2017. Both elements are central to understanding the changes in perceived deportation risk faced by binational couples.

3. Data and Sample Construction

3.1. Data

This paper uses data from the American Community Survey (ACS), a nationally representative annual survey conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau. We rely on ACS waves from 2008 to 2019. The large sample size—approximately 1 percent of the U.S. population each year—allows us to identify a sufficient number of binational couples and observe marriage transitions at annual frequency.

We use harmonized microdata from IPUMS-USA ([Steven Ruggles and Sobek, 2017](#)), which ensures consistent variable definitions across survey waves. The ACS is particularly well suited for this study because it provides detailed information on household relationships, marital status, citizenship status, birthplace, and the retrospective year of marriage and naturalization. These variables allow us to identify cohabiting couples, classify their citizenship composition, and reconstruct marriage transitions over time.

In addition to the ACS, we incorporate information from several external data sources to

characterize the local policy environment. Data on Primary Election in 2016 are obtained from Bucknell University Election Data Center ([Bucknell University, 2017](#)) and the 2016 U.S. Election dataset on GitHub ([Hamner, 2017](#)). Data on Sanctuary City policies are obtained from the replication package of [Alsan and Yang \(2024\)](#). Information on the rollout of the Secure Communities program and other local enforcement immigration policies is drawn from the replication materials accompanying [East and Velásquez \(2024\)](#). Finally, data on ICE detentions are obtained from The Deportation Data Project and data on removals under SC were obtained directly from tables in the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC) database website. These external datasets are merged with the ACS at the appropriate geographic and temporal levels and are used to complement the individual- and household-level information contained in the survey.

3.2. Sample Construction

Our unit of analysis is the couple. We identify couples in the ACS as two individuals within the same household where one is listed as the household head and the other reports being either the spouse or an unmarried partner. The sample is therefore restricted to cohabiting couples observed at the time of the survey. We limit attention to individuals between ages 16 and 60.

We classify couples as married if both partners report being married and the spouse is present in the household. Couples are classified as unmarried if the relationship is reported as “unmarried partner” and the household head reports a non-married status (never married, divorced, separated, or widowed). Our focus is on the legal status of the current union, rather than the individual’s marital history.

The outcome of interest is an indicator for whether an unmarried couple transitions into marriage in a given year. Couples already married in a given year are excluded from the risk set. Because the ACS reports the year—but not the month—of marriage and naturalization, we assign marital and citizenship status at the annual level. Individuals reporting being

unmarried in year t are treated as unmarried throughout that year, and transitions are recorded at the annual frequency.

We define a couple as binational if one partner is a U.S. citizen and the other is a noncitizen. Couples are defined as homogeneous if both partners share the same citizenship status. From this group, we exclude couples in which citizenship was acquired through naturalization, as these unions may have previously been binational and therefore exposed to immigration-related risk prior to naturalization.

We construct the sample using two complementary approaches: a cross-sectional design and a short retrospective pseudo-panel. In the cross-sectional sample, marital and citizenship status are defined as reported in the survey year, and each couple enters the sample only once. This approach provides a clean snapshot of couple composition but yields a relatively small number of marriage transitions among binational couples in any given year.

To increase statistical power, we exploit the retrospective information in the ACS on year of marriage and year of naturalization. These variables allow us to reconstruct marital and citizenship status up to two years prior to the survey year. The pseudo-panel therefore expands the effective number of couple-year observations. The key identifying assumption is that couples observed in year t were already formed and cohabiting in year $t - n$, with $n \in 1, 2$ ³

Table 1 compares observable characteristics across the cross-sectional sample and the pseudo-panel constructed using one- and two-year retrospective windows. As expected, the pseudo-panel differs in some characteristics from the cross-section. Couples identified through longer retrospective windows exhibit higher levels of education, income, and asset ownership, and are more likely to be in second or higher-order unions to have had a birth in the prior year. By contrast, we do not observe substantial differences in age, employment

³For example, consider a couple observed in the 2018 ACS. Using information on year of marriage and year of naturalization, we can reconstruct their marital and citizenship status in 2016 and 2017. If the couple married in 2016 and the foreign partner naturalized that same year, we classify them as a binational unmarried couple at the beginning of 2016 and record a transition into marriage in that year.

status of both partners, and in the total number of children in the house. The differences across samples, therefore reflect selection into longer cohabitation spells rather than simple aging.

These differences arise mechanically from the panel construction. Pseudo-panel conditions on couples observed as cohabiting in t , and assume that the couple was already formed in $t - 1$ and $t - 2$, introducing two potential mechanical biases relative to the cross-section. The first one relates to couples who broke up between the time window, affecting by inflating the numerator (i.e couples who get married in a given year). This acts as a sort of survival filter, retaining proportionally more married couples than unmarried ones, because the former are more likely to remain together until year t having married in $t - 1$ and $t - 2$.⁴ The compositional shifts observed in Table 1, arise because those who marry are, on average, more educated and economically sustainable, mature in age, and in more stable unions who consequently transition into the parenting period.

The second source of bias relates to new couple formations and affects the denominator (i.e all couples living together in a given year). The assumption that unmarried couples in t were already cohabiting in $t - 1$, $t - 2$, expands the risk set, potentially adding more couples than the true unobserved stock of couples in previous years. Note that this bias goes in the opposite direction to the first one. Empirically, the first bias dominates, as higher marriage rates are observed in the pseudo-panel than in the cross section. Crucially, to our specification, neither bias seems to operate differentially across groups, something that we confirmed when inspecting parallel pre-trends.

These compositional differences are important for interpreting the magnitude of the estimated effects across samples. In all specifications, we control for the full set of observable characteristics and include indicators for the source of the observation (cross-section, one-year

⁴The observed marriage rate in the pseudo-panel equals $\frac{N_m \cdot p_m}{N_u \cdot p_u}$, while the true population rate in a given year is $\frac{N_m}{N_u}$, where N_m and N_u denote couples who married and did not marry in $(t-1, t-2)$, respectively, and p_m, p_u are their corresponding probabilities of surviving as a cohabiting couple until period t . Since marriage stabilizes unions, $p_m > p_u$, so the survival filter retains proportionally more cases from the numerator than from the denominator.

Table 1: Summary Statistics by Sample

Variable	Cross-Section	Panel 1	Panel 2
Observation	682655	780590	852578
Binational Couples	41265	55440	68197
Binational Couples (%)	6.04	7.10	8.00
Marriage rate	0.108	0.153	0.156
Binational	0.189	0.254	0.250
Control	0.103	0.146	0.149
Educ (Head): Low	0.066	0.063	0.060
Educ (Head): Mid	0.637	0.628	0.619
Educ (Head): High	0.297	0.309	0.320
Educ (Partner): Low	0.087	0.083	0.080
Educ (Partner): Mid	0.668	0.659	0.651
Educ (Partner): High	0.245	0.258	0.269
Age grp: 18-24	0.141	0.141	0.138
Age grp: 25-34	0.379	0.390	0.400
Age grp: 35-44	0.220	0.218	0.217
Age grp: 45-54	0.187	0.180	0.175
Age grp: 55+	0.074	0.071	0.070
Age diff: 0-2	0.450	0.456	0.460
Age diff: 3-5	0.272	0.271	0.270
Age diff: 6-10	0.136	0.134	0.133
Age diff: 11-15	0.070	0.068	0.067
Age diff: 15+	0.073	0.071	0.070
Mar order (Head): 1st	0.576	0.518	0.473
Mar order (Head): 2nd	0.310	0.350	0.382
Mar order (Head): 3+	0.114	0.132	0.145
Mar order (Partner): 1st	0.592	0.533	0.487
Mar order (Partner): 2nd	0.300	0.342	0.376
Mar order (Partner): 3+	0.108	0.124	0.137
Employed (Head)	0.836	0.839	0.843
Not emp. (Head)	0.164	0.161	0.157
Employed (Partner)	0.768	0.771	0.774
Not emp. (Partner)	0.232	0.229	0.226
Fertility (last yr)	0.061	0.066	0.073
Num. children	0.774	0.773	0.778
Rooms	5.390	5.409	5.435
Mortgage	1.232	1.252	1.276
Any health ins.	0.828	0.836	0.844
HH income	77319.6	78702.7	80224.9

Source: Own author calculation based on ACS data.

panel, or two-year panel), ensuring that differences in couple composition do not mechanically drive the results. In the results section, we show that the estimates are of similar magnitude and consistent across the three samples and that the difference arises in the later years of the treatment period. Nevertheless, in most of the following sections, we restrict to the cross-section and 1-year panel as the preferred specification for estimates, adding the 2-year sample when inspecting the dynamics of the effect.

4. Empirical Strategy

We propose an identification strategy following a diff-in-diff setting, in which we exploit the temporal variation in the uncertainty of immigration enforcement policies from the 2016 presidential campaign onward and the variation in the degree of exposure regarding immigration status for different groups. More precisely, we compare the evolution of marriage rates among individuals potentially affected by immigration policy with those not affected, before and after 2015.

The choice of treatment period reflects the fact that campaign proposals gained credibility through the primary elections held in the first half of 2016 and were ultimately validated by the November general election. Our treatment group are binational cohabiting unmarried couples, defined as union between a U.S.-born individual and a foreign-born, non-citizen partner. The control group are homogeneous cohabiting unmarried couples, defined as unions between two U.S. citizens or, more restrictively, between two U.S.-born individuals.

Binational couples are differentially exposed to immigration-related uncertainty because the legal status of one member of the household is directly affected by expectations regarding future changes in immigration policy and enforcement. By contrast, cohabiting couples composed exclusively of U.S. citizens are not directly exposed to such uncertainty and therefore provide a comparison group to capture common time trends in marriage behavior unrelated to immigration status.

Heightened immigration-related uncertainty may affect marriage decisions by increasing

the perceived costs of remaining in an informal or non-institutionalized union. For binational couples, formalizing the relationship through marriage can reduce uncertainty regarding household stability, future separation risk, and interactions with public institutions. As a result, increases in uncertainty may accelerate or increase transitions into marriage among couples already close to formalization.

Under the assumption that, absent the increase in immigration-related uncertainty, marriage trends among these groups would have evolved similarly, differences from 2016 onward in marriage behavior can be attributed to differential exposure to immigration policy uncertainty. We assess the plausibility of this assumption through descriptive trends and an event-study specification. Appendix Figures A.2 and A.3 show no substantial differences in the slopes prior to 2015 across the cross-sectional and pseudo-panel samples, with a subsequent increase in marriage rates registered only for binational couples.⁵ Event-study estimates presented in the next section further support the validity of this assumption

The causal effect of the uncertainty regarding migration on marriage rate is estimated with the following model:

$$Y_{ist} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{Binat}_i + \beta_2 \text{Post}_t + \beta_3 (\text{Binat}_i \times \text{Post}_t) + \gamma X_{ist} + \theta Z_{st} + \delta_t + \mu_s + \varepsilon_{ist}, \quad (1)$$

where Y_{ist} denotes the marriage outcome for couple i residing in state s in year t . Binat_i is an indicator equal to one for binational cohabiting unmarried couples, and Post_t captures the post-treatment period defined as 2016 onward. The coefficient of interest, β_3 , measures the differential change in marriage rates among binational couples relative to the control group following the increase in immigration-related uncertainty.

The vector X_{ist} includes a rich set of couple-level controls, capturing educational attainment of both partners, age and age differences within the couple, marital history, fertility in last year and number of children in the household, housing characteristics, employment

⁵For the cross-sectional sample, two-year averages are reported given the relatively small number of binational couples observed in any given year.

status of each partner, total household income and access to health insurance, indicators for the retrospective window used in the pseudo-panel construction and unauthorized immigrant status indicator ⁶.

The vector Z_{st} includes time-varying state-level characteristics, such as labor market conditions measured by unemployment and employment rate, median wage growth, housing market indicators measured by HPI index and median gross rent, and measures of the local immigrant environment, capturing the share of immigrant in construction and services. All specifications include year fixed effects, δ_t , and state fixed effects, μ_s , which absorb common shocks over time and time-invariant differences across states, respectively. Standard errors are clustered at the state level.

Couples of same sex are excluded from the main analysis to avoid confounding our estimates with differential changes at the state level regarding legalization of same sex marriage, which took place during the same period. In the most complete specification we include to the main equation an interaction for DACA eligibility with year indicators (2012–2019). The terms capture potential eligibility to the DACA program, a specific immigration policy that was launched in 2012, that may affect differentially to the binational couple as an option to temporarily differ the deportation threat. Importantly, in our samples the share of eligible for the program among binational couples is stable and relatively low, around 13.4% of this group.

To further test the validity of our identification strategy, we estimate an event study specification of the following form:

$$Y_{ist} = \alpha + \sum_{\tau \neq \tau_0} \beta_{\tau} (\text{Binat}_i \times \mathbb{1}\{t = \tau\}) + \gamma X_{ist} + \theta Z_{st} + \delta_t + \mu_s + \varepsilon_{ist}, \quad (2)$$

where $\mathbb{1}\{t = \tau\}$ is an indicator for each calendar year relative to the event, and τ_0 denotes the reference (baseline) year. We present estimations considering two alternative baseline years, 2014 and 2015. While 2015 is the natural reference year given that the treatment

⁶We follow the methodology of [Borjas \(2017\)](#) to identify unauthorized immigrants. See section 7.1

period is defined from 2016 onward, Trump’s candidacy announcement in mid-2015 may have already triggered early responses, making 2014 a more conservative baseline. The coefficients β_τ trace the dynamic evolution of marriage rates among binational couples relative to the control group before and after Trump announcement for presidential the election.

To account for pre-treatment changes in immigration enforcement policies executed via the Secure Communities rollout and 287g agreements, the dynamic specification incorporates an enforcement term interacted with year indicators covering the period up to 2014, when the SC rollout was completed, thereby affecting only pre-period coefficients. The pre-period dynamics remain essentially unchanged by the inclusion of these additional controls. The event study specification allows us to visually and statistically assess the presence of pre-treatment trends, examining the timing of the response following the treatment event.

5. Results

Table 2 reports the estimates for the coefficient of interest capturing the effect on marriage transitions following the increase in immigration policy uncertainty from 2016 onward. To present our main results, we first report estimates based on the cross-sectional specification, as the sample size is large enough for a precise estimation of the aggregated effect and avoids any potential compositional changes mechanically introduced by the construction of the pseudo-panel. Across all specifications presented in this table, we find a positive and statistically significant effect.

Column (1) reports the baseline specification without controls, yielding an estimated increase of 1.91 percentage points ($sd = 0.0053$) in the marriage rate of binational couples relative to couples in which both members are U.S. citizens. The coefficient of interest decreases to 1.4 percentage point and it is more precisely estimated ($sd = 0.0028$) when incorporating the full set of controls, including individual characteristics of both partners as well as couple-level and household controls. The size of the point estimate corresponds to a 7.3 percent increase relative to the pre-treatment mean of the control group (0.191).

Column (3) adds state-level macroeconomic controls to account for potential effects of regional economic conditions on marriage decisions in a given year. These controls include labor market indicators, housing market conditions, and the share of immigrants employed in construction and services, thereby accounting for industry-specific dynamics particularly relevant for the treated population. The estimated effect is unchanged and remains statistically significant under this specification.

Column (4) controls for couples in which the immigrant member is potentially eligible for the DACA program, which was in effect between 2012 and 2019. Previous research has documented an increase in marriage rates among illegible couples around 2014. The estimated post-period effect reaches 1.78 percentage points ($sd = 0.0035$) under this specification. The pattern is consistent with DACA having previously raised marriage rates among eligible individuals, thereby attenuating the additional marriage response to subsequent immigration enforcement shocks. Accounting for DACA suggests that the measured effect reflects a broader response among binational couples rather than behavior driven by targeted immigration programs.

Finally, Column (5) evaluates whether the effect is driven by cases in which the immigrant member of the binational couple is likely undocumented, following the methodology proposed by [Borjas \(2017\)](#). We find that the estimated effect persists and rises to 1.89 percentage points ($sd = 0.0034$). Under our most comprehensive specification, the increase in immigration-related uncertainty among binational couples leads to a 1.89 percentage point increase in the probability of marriage, corresponding to a sizeable 9.9 percent increase relative to the pre-treatment average.

Table A.5 in the Appendix replicates the estimates from Table 2 using the pseudo-panel specification with one- and two-year retrospective windows. The cross-sectional and the pseudo-panel estimates are not very different in magnitude, but the panel is more precisely estimated. The relative magnitude is smaller in the one-year panel sample ($0.0159/0.256$), reflecting differences in the point estimates and in the pre-treatment mean. In the two-year

Table 2: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage Transitions. Cross section sample.

	Get Married				
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0191*** (0.0053)	0.0140*** (0.0028)	0.0139*** (0.0029)	0.0178*** (0.0035)	0.0189*** (0.0034)
Observations (000s)	69390.7	69390.7	69390.7	69390.7	69390.7
R-squared	0.011	0.383	0.383	0.383	0.383
Mean Treated (Pre)	0.191	0.191	0.191	0.191	0.191
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	NO	YES	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	NO	NO	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	NO	NO	NO	YES	YES
Undocument controls	NO	NO	NO	NO	YES

Notes: The table reports difference-in-differences estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to one if a cohabiting unmarried couple transitions into marriage in a given calendar year. Column (1) includes state and year fixed effects only. Column (2) adds individual and couple-level controls. Column (3) further incorporates state-level macroeconomic controls. Column (4) adds DACA eligibility interactions with year indicators. Column (5) controls for likely unauthorized immigrant status following Borjas (2017). The pre-treatment mean corresponds to the average marriage transition rate among binational couples before the treatment period. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

panel sample, the point estimate is instead slightly larger in magnitude (1.97 p,p), but closer in terms of the relative effect size obtained in the cross-section (7.9 percent, 0.0197/0.248).

The results show consistently positive and statistically significant coefficients across all specifications and samples, reinforcing the robustness of the main findings.⁷ The cross-sectional specification provides a transparent benchmark to validate the pseudo-panel estimations, which allow us to exploit additional variation and obtain more precise estimates.

The difference in pre-treatment means between the cross-sectional and pseudo-panel samples is expected, given the compositional changes introduced mechanically by reconstructing couple trajectories, as discussed previously. The pseudo-panel captures more stable and mature couples, who therefore exhibit higher baseline marriage rates. Consistent with this, in

⁷Results remain positive and significant when the post-treatment period is defined as starting in 2017, coinciding with the formal reinstatement of Secure Communities and the tightening of enforcement measures, ruling out that the findings are driven by spurious behavioral responses unrelated to enforcement uncertainty (Table A.6)

the 2-year sample where the selection is more pronounced, increases in immigration-related uncertainty may have a larger marginal impact among such over-represented unions, which are closer to formalization.

The pseudo-panel sample is particularly useful to assess the validity of our identification strategy through an event study. Figure 1 plots the point estimates and standard errors in each year relative to baseline, for each sample. We use 2014 as our baseline in the most conservative specification. It represents the last full year of pre-treatment before the rise in anti-immigrant rhetoric and the shift in expectations surrounding immigration policy, associated with the launch of Donald Trump’s presidential campaign in 2015. Although the 2015 point estimate is not statistically different from zero, we avoid relying on a period potentially affected by increasing uncertainty, as it may already capture anticipatory responses, temporary postponement or adjustment behavior.

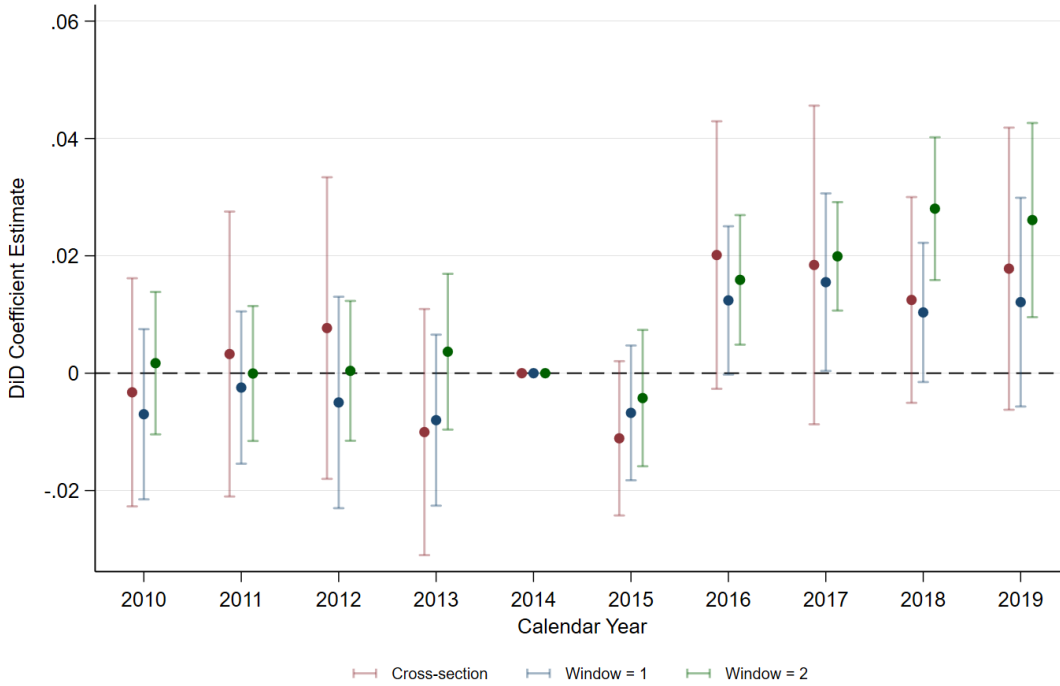
Across the three samples and alternative baseline years, pre-treatment coefficients are small in magnitude and statistically indistinguishable from zero, providing no evidence of differential pre-trends between treatment and control groups. In contrast, post-2015 estimates are positive and statistically significant, consistent with an increase in marriage transitions among binational couples after the shift in immigration policy expectations.

Notably, the response is already visible in 2016, prior to the formal reinstatement of Secure Communities and to any other enforcement measures being implemented. This suggests that the marriage response was driven not only by realized enforcement but also by the shift in immigration policy expectations associated with the electoral campaign. Further in the text, we test whether this anticipatory pattern is consistent with the credibility of Trump’s candidacy gaining ground through the primary elections.

As a robustness check, we replicate the estimation using 2015 and a pooled 2014–2015 as an alternative reference baselines in the Appendix (1 and A.4a). In both cases, post-treatment effects are larger in magnitude, anticipatory effects are also found and pre-trends are equally ruled out. It is also worth noting that estimates from the three samples are

relatively similar and close in magnitude for 2016 and 2017, starting to slightly diverge for 2018-2019 in the 2-year pseudo-panel, which remains steadily positive. The effect dynamics confirm the relatively more pronounced effect discussed for the 2-year sample and reveals that the divergence emerges only in the later periods.

Figure 1: Effect of increase in immigration-related uncertainty on marriages. Event Study estimates. Cross-section and pseudo-panel samples.



Notes: The figure reports event-study coefficients from equation (2), estimating the differential change in marriage transitions for binational couples relative to homogeneous citizen couples. The omitted category is 2014. The specification includes the full set of controls, state, year fixed effects and enforcement terms interacted with year indicators for the pre-period. Bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. Estimates are presented for each sample. The pseudo-panel data are reconstructed from retrospective ACS information. Source: Own author calculation based on ACS data.

6. Transition into marriage and new couple formation

The higher probability of getting married in binational couples could be interpreted as an insurance response of the household to the higher risk of the immigration policy, but also as the result of the policy leading to new couple formations. Individuals may accelerate the couple matching and union formalization by looking for and locking in partners with

citizenship, as a way to legally navigate the uncertainty regarding migration status. In extreme cases, this could lead to fake marriages or marrying exclusively for legal purposes.

The difference in both mechanism, depend on who are the couples getting married. The marriage-as-insurance mechanism is consistent with already-cohabiting couples marginally transitioning into formal marriage as a way to secure immigration status and protect accumulated investments in shared human capital, labor networks, and social ties.

We can exploit the survey information on prior residence location to infer cohabitation and identify new couples. For each member of the household observed in t , we can reconstruct whether in $t - 1$, they were living in the same house or, in case of moving, the location of origin at the PUMA level. From there, we separate observed household in (i) already living together in the same house, (ii) couples that migrate together from the same origin, and (iii) couples where both or at least one member was living in a different location.⁸

The last group corresponds to "new households", as we observed them together in t , knowing that in $t - 1$ they were in different houses. We tagged the "strictly cohabiting" group as the ones living in the same house, given that we are certain that they remain in the same place, same house. For the group of both partners moving from the same location, plausibly many of those cases include couples already living together but in a different area. We join them to the group of cohabiting, for sure, under a more flexible criterion of cohabitation.

Table 3 shows that the estimated effect is concentrated in already-cohabiting couples, regardless of adopting the strict or more flexible categories to identify that group. The coefficient in both cases is slightly larger than in the full-sample estimates, but more importantly, the estimated effect relative to the pre-treatment mean is considerably more pronounced, amounting to 15.2% ($0.0212/0.139$) for strictly cohabiting couples. This is explained by the lower baseline marriage rate among already-cohabiting households relative to newly formed ones (0.139 vs 0.347 respectively), which amplifies the magnitude of the relative effect.

⁸This last group includes: both members moving from different locations each; one mover, one non-mover; one in the US and one abroad; and both members living abroad last year.

Table 3: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage Transitions by cohabitation status. Cross-section sample.

	Get Married			
	Full Sample	Strict Cohabit.	Flex Cohabit.	New Household
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0189*** (0.0034)	0.0212*** (0.0057)	0.0206*** (0.0049)	0.0089 (0.0118)
Observations (000s)	69390.7	43893.2	59140.0	10250.6
R-squared	0.383	0.322	0.373	0.448
Mean Treated (Pre)	0.191	0.139	0.159	0.348
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	YES	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	YES	YES	YES	YES
Undocument controls	YES	YES	YES	YES

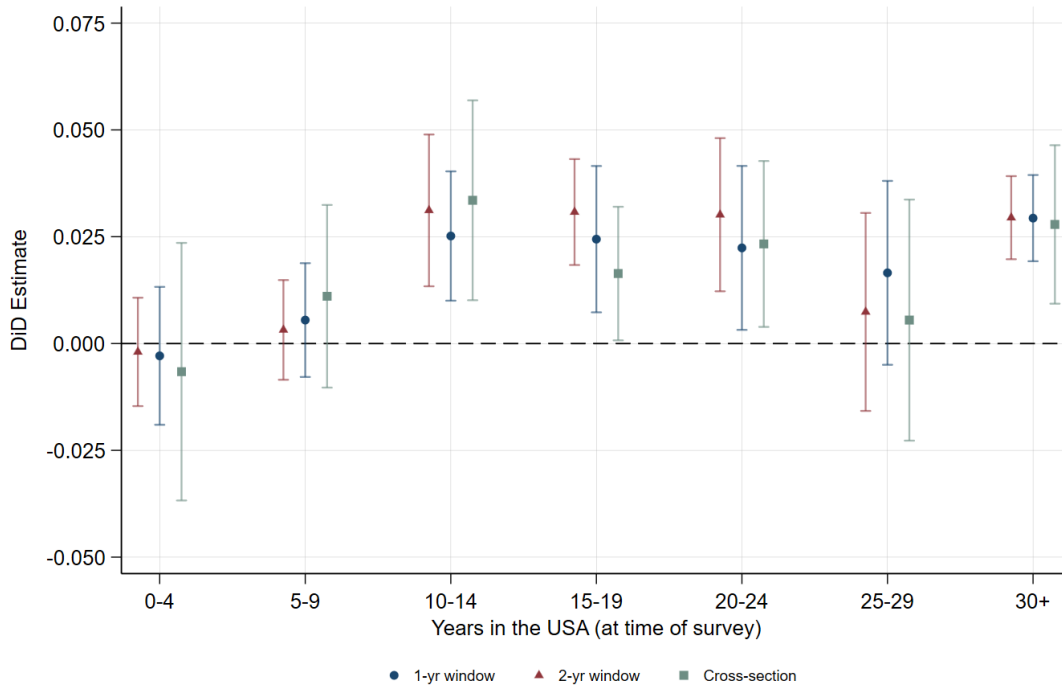
Notes: The table reports difference-in-differences estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples by cohabitation status. The estimates follow from the same specification detailed in Table 2. Column (1) includes the full sample. Columns (2)–(4) restrict to subgroups defined by the inferred living arrangement of the couple in the year prior to observation. *Strict Cohabit* includes couples where both partners were already living together in the same house; *Flex Cohabit* includes couples who moved from the same origin location, a broader cohabitation category that plausibly captures pairs already living together but relocating to a new area; and *New Household* includes couples where both members moved from different locations, one moved and one did not, one partner was abroad, or both were living abroad. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Among already-cohabiting couples, the response is further concentrated among those with the longest U.S. tenure of the non-citizen member. Figure 2 shows that the estimated effect is statistically indistinguishable from zero for immigrants with fewer than ten years in the country, and activates sharply among those with a decade or more of residence. This gradient is difficult to reconcile with a panic-driven response, which would predict the opposite pattern. Instead, the evidence points to immigrants who arrived years earlier, at young or adult ages, and have since been living in the United States (see Figures A.5 in the Appendix). The stakes are expected to be higher for this group, making the legal formalization valuable to them.

These results in this section validate that the marriage response is driven by the formalization of pre-existing unions rather than by the formation of new ones, consistent with the

marriage-as-insurance mechanism. The analysis also reveals that, conditioning on previous cohabitation, the shift in the immigration policy uncertainty induced marriage transitions with an even larger effect, and such transitions are undertaken by immigrants who have been living in Us for a decade or more.

Figure 2: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage Transitions by years since non-citizen member migrated to the US.



Notes: The figure reports estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples. Each point is a separate estimate on the subsample of non-binational and binational couples where the immigrant member falls within that years-in-residence block. Blocks are defined in 5-year intervals; all observations with 30 or more years are pooled. Sample is restricted to already-cohabiting couples. Bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the state level. Pseudo-panel data are reconstructed from retrospective ACS information. Source: Own author calculation based on ACS data.

7. Heterogeneous Effects by Immigration Profile

To further support the previous finding and to understand the scope of the immigration enforcement policy, in this section, we document heterogeneous effects across particular sub-populations of immigrants and also by geographic exposure to enforcement and anti-

immigration environments.

A consistent history for the marriage as a form of insurance would imply detecting transition into marriage at higher rates for groups that are more likely to be reached by the enforcement measures or for whom the consequences of that enforcement would be higher. Throughout this section, we report results for the cross-sectional and one-year pseudo-panel samples; estimates based on the two-year window are presented in Appendix Table A.7 and support the same substantive conclusions.

7.1. Unauthorized immigration

Following the methodology of [Borjas \(2017\)](#), we indirectly identify potential unauthorized immigrants in the ACS by classifying as legally authorized those foreign-born individuals who are naturalized citizens, arrived before 1980, are veterans, work in the government sector, receive SSI, Medicaid or Medicare benefits, are employed in licensed occupations, or are students likely to hold temporary legal visas. The remaining foreign-born noncitizens are classified as likely unauthorized. We then consider the legal status of the noncitizen spouse based on these criteria. Approximately 30% of the binational couples are classified as likely authorized across our samples.⁹

If likely undocumented immigrants face a higher level of uncertainty and a higher risk of being arrested and deported, we would expect that the effect on marriages for this subgroup will be higher, as the marital union acts as the most direct legal channel toward regularization.¹⁰ Even when adjustment is not immediately feasible, marriage may improve access to legal relief and reduce deportation risk in expected terms.

Table 4 in columns (1)-(2) shows that the post-2015 increase in marriage rates is concentrated among binational couples with an unauthorized immigrant member. In the cross-

⁹It is important to note that this is an approximation of the undocumented population, and not a exact definition of the status.

¹⁰As immediate relatives of citizens, undocumented spouses may become eligible for adjustment of status (conditional on lawful entry), apply for permanent residency or obtain temporary work authorization during the process.

sectional data, only the coefficient for this group is positive and statistically significant, showing a marginal increase in marriages of 2.22 percentage points ($sd = 0.0042$), a 10.8 percent increase relative to the pre-treatment mean. In the one-year pseudo-panel, the estimated effect for unauthorized remains significant (1.80 p.p., $sd = 0.0036$), corresponding to 6.6 percent relative to the pre-treatment mean. In this sample, the coefficient for authorized couples, although smaller in magnitude, reaches statistical significance at the 5 percent level (1.19 p.p., $sd = 0.0056$). Despite this, the difference between the two groups is not statistically significant in either sample ($p = 0.25$ and $p = 0.36$ in the one-year panel), reflecting the imprecision in the authorized group estimate.¹¹

7.2. Targeted Nationalities

In a similar spirit, we identify binational couples where the immigrant member has a targeted nationality. The anti-immigrant rhetoric and the local enforcement activities were notoriously concentrated in specific sub-groups of immigrants, specially those coming from Mexico and Latin America, Africa, Russia and Middle Eastern countries, some of which were explicitly targeted by the travel ban¹². Based on the country of origin, we classify a person as a targeted immigrant if was born in any of these countries. Approximately 29% of the binational couples has a member from a targeted nationality.¹³

Consistent with the finding for the case of unauthorized, in Table 4, in columns (3)-(4), we present evidence that the increase in marriage rates is concentrated on a binational couple with one of the members having a targeted nationality. Across both samples, we observe a marked positive effect statistically different from zero: 2.44 p.p. in the cross-section (13.8

¹¹In the Table in the Appendix, we exclude results from the two-year pseudo-panel sample because several criteria used in the classification, such as occupational category, employment in the government sector, or participation in public benefit programs, cannot be reliably reconstructed retrospectively and may also change with marital status.

¹²This category includes individuals born in Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Oman, Lebanon, Syria, Iraq, Iran, Jordan, Kuwait, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Turkey, Israel/Palestine, Afghanistan, Armenia, Georgia, Azerbaijan, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, and Sri Lanka.

¹³As the country of origin is a time-invariant characteristic, we are more reliable in the 2-year pseudo-panel sample for this exercise, than in the case of unauthorized status

percent relative to the pre-treatment mean) and 2.23 p.p. in the one-year panel (9.3 percent). In contrast, the point estimate for non-targeted nationalities is low and not distinguishable from zero in either sample. The observed difference between groups is statistically significant in both samples ($p = 0.012$ and $p = 0.001$).

7.3. Education

We then explore whether there are heterogeneous effects by the educational level of the household head or first member in the couple (as declared in ACS). We expect lower-educated immigrants being more likely to work in informal or low-skilled occupations with greater exposure to local law enforcement and fewer institutional protections, which may increase both their perceived and actual risk of detection. Also, they typically have fewer financial resources to afford legal representation and may face greater informational constraints when navigating complex immigration procedures.¹⁴

Table 4 in columns (5)-(6) supports the hypothesis of a stronger response among low- and middle-educated immigrants. For the cross-section and a 1-year pseudo-panel sample, we obtained a marginally positive increase in the marriage rates only for this group, being close in magnitude (2.07 p.p and 2.02 p.p) and statistically different from zero in both cases ($sd = 0.0044$ and 0.0033 , respectively), corresponding to 12.5 and 9.0 percent increases relative to the respective pre-treatment means. In contrast, we cannot detect a sizeable effect for the highly educated group in either sample. The difference between the education groups is statistically significant in both the cross-section and the one-year panel ($p = 0.028$ and $p = 0.001$, respectively).¹⁵

¹⁴In addition, compared to higher-educated immigrants, they are less likely to have access to alternative legal channels of regularization, such as employment-based visas or employer sponsorship. In contrast, higher-educated immigrants may possess greater economic resources, stronger networks, and alternative adjustment options, reducing the marginal incentive to respond to enforcement shocks through marriage. Among already-cohabiting couples, the response is further concentrated among those with the longest U.S. tenure of the non-citizen member.

¹⁵Results for the 2-year pseudo panel show a positive and significant effect for both groups, 2.12 p.p for low-mid and 1.18 p.p. for high educ. Although different from the previous two panels, the results are consistent with this sample, which captures more educated, high socioeconomic status, and long-standing

Table 4: Heterogeneous Effects by Household Profile. Cross-section and One-Year Pseudo-panel Samples.

	Authorization Status		Targeted Status		Education Level		Children under 16	
	Unauthorized	Authorized	Targeted	Non-Targeted	Low-Mid	High	Child <16	No Child <16
Panel A: Cross-Section Sample								
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0222*** (0.0042)	0.0123 (0.0075)	0.0244*** (0.0047)	0.0045 (0.0065)	0.0207*** (0.0044)	0.0047 (0.0058)	0.0275*** (0.0059)	0.0074 (0.0046)
Mean Treated (Pre)	0.2057	0.1534	0.1769	0.2328	0.1658	0.2666	0.1507	0.2311
Observations (000s)	68071.0	66082.4	68210.0	65943.4	51139.4	18251.3	27410.6	41980.1
R-squared	0.382	0.373	0.379	0.377	0.319	0.549	0.344	0.432
Panel B: Pseudo-Panel (1-Year)								
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0180*** (0.0036)	0.0119** (0.0056)	0.0223*** (0.0040)	-0.0004 (0.0052)	0.0202*** (0.0033)	0.0004 (0.0049)	0.0196*** (0.0041)	0.0094** (0.0039)
Mean Treated (Pre)	0.2735	0.2122	0.2407	0.2997	0.2252	0.3380	0.2217	0.2886
Observations (000s)	145622.0	141022.7	145896.3	140748.4	107479.0	41278.1	58755.2	90001.9
R-squared	0.373	0.367	0.371	0.369	0.328	0.468	0.358	0.393
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Macro Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
DACA Eligible	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Undocument Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES

Notes: The table reports difference-in-differences estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples. The number of observations reported for the unauthorized and targeted status columns reflects all homogeneous couples plus the subset of binational couples belonging to each subgroup, as these classifications apply exclusively to the noncitizen member of binational couples. For the education and child under 16 columns, the split applies to both homogeneous and binational couples. Binational couples with an unauthorized immigrant member were imputed following the methodology of [Borjas \(2017\)](#). Targeted immigrants are defined based on country of birth, including Mexico, Latin America, Africa, Russia, and selected Middle Eastern countries, as described in the text. Low-mid education includes primary and secondary schooling, whereas high education refers to post-secondary attainment. The education level of the household head is considered. The presence of a child indicates at least one child 16 years old or younger living in the household. The estimates follow from the most complete specification detailed in Table 2. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

7.4. Presence of a child

Finally, we explore heterogeneity by the presence of children in the household. If the household internalizes the perceived deportation risk and its associated family costs, we should observe stronger effects among couples with children. For binational couples without children, separation, while costly, may be partially reversible through relocation or delayed reunification. In contrast, for couples with children, forced separation entails substantially higher emotional and economic costs, with long-term implications for child development and household stability.

Table 4 in columns (7)–(8) presents evidence consistent with a stronger response among couples with at least one child under age 16 in the household. In the cross-sectional sample, only the coefficient for the group with children is positive and statistically significant, amounting to 2.75 percentage points ($sd = 0.0059$). This corresponds to an 18.2 percent increase relative to the pre-treatment mean of binational couples with children (0.151), notably larger than the baseline effect for the full sample. By contrast, the estimated effect for couples without children is small (0.74 p.p.) and statistically indistinguishable from zero ($sd = 0.0046$).

The one-year pseudo-panel corroborates this pattern: the effect for couples with children remains positive and statistically significant (1.96 p.p., $sd = 0.0041$), whereas the coefficient for couples without children, although marginally significant at the 5 percent level (0.94 p.p., $sd = 0.0039$), is approximately half the size and corresponds to a considerably smaller relative effect (3.3 percent relative to the pre-treatment mean). The difference between the two groups is statistically significant in the cross-section ($p = 0.007$) and in the one-year panel ($p = 0.069$). Taken together, the results indicate that the marriage response is substantially more pronounced among couples with children, in line with the notion that the prospect of

couples. Indeed, by comparing the observations between the 1-year and the 2-year samples, the increase in the sample size is coming only from an increase in the highly educated column. Couples of these characteristics who have been together for longer are more prone to marginally increase the formalization of the union. This is consistent with an increase for both groups.

family separation generates the largest response for households with dependent children.

Overall, our findings for the effect in groups analyzed, are consistent with responses in marriages being concentrated and higher for sub-groups facing a higher degree of uncertainty regarding the migration policy and a higher probability of being targeted by the immigration enforcement.

8. Geographic exposure and anticipatory responses

Differences in households' geographic exposure to immigration enforcement policy may also amplify or dampen their response. Given the same national-level shock—such as a presidential election—local or subnational variation can either attenuate or reinforce risk perception.

We first explore heterogeneous responses in sanctuary-declared areas. We then examine whether the credibility of Trump's candidacy, measured by Republican primary results, led to stronger responses in areas where Trump was perceived as more competitive, and whether this helps explain the anticipatory effects evidenced for 2016.

8.1. Sanctuary Cities

Sanctuary cities are local jurisdictions that limit cooperation with federal immigration enforcement by restricting ICE detainers or limiting information sharing with federal authorities. Sanctuary policies expanded gradually following the initial rollout of Secure Communities in 2008, with a more pronounced wave of adoptions around 2014 and again in 2017, often as an explicit institutional response to federal enforcement efforts.

Although the jurisdiction can not prevent federal enforcement directly, the sanctuary status implied a reduction in detention and deportation risk for undocumented immigrants between 2010 and 2015 ([Hausman, 2020](#)), by weakening the channels through which local law enforcement collaborates with federal immigration authorities. Sanctuary cities reduced deportations mainly in cases of people with no criminal convictions, and not for those with violent convictions. Given the protection offered by these cities, a smaller effect on marriages

would be expected.

Nevertheless, sanctuary cities were intentionally targeted during the tightening of enforcement activities. Shortly after taking office, Trump signed Executive Order 13768, threatening to cut federal funds to jurisdictions maintaining sanctuary status. In fact, Miami-Dade County capitulated almost immediately, signaling that the threat was credible. If households perceived that the protection previously guaranteed was at risk and directly targeted, they may have transitioned into marriage at higher rates in anticipation of the removal of sanctuary status. The expected effect is therefore dual and remains theoretically indeterminate.

We gather data on sanctuary jurisdictions from [Alsan and Yang \(2024\)](#), who document sanctuary status through 2017 using ICE administrative records. We complement this dataset with information on jurisdictions adopting sanctuary policies between 2016 and 2019, using data from the Immigrant Legal Resource Center (ILRC). The map for the distribution of Sanctuary areas and their timing is offering in Figure A.6.

In our empirical analysis, we focus on jurisdictions that had declared sanctuary status prior to the treatment period, excluding areas that adopted sanctuary policies after 2016. This restriction ensures that sanctuary designation is predetermined with respect to the post-treatment period, thus avoiding contamination from jurisdictions that changed their status during the period under study.¹⁶

Table A.8 in the Appendix presents the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions, distinguishing by sanctuary status (panels A and B) and splitting the whole sample by cohabitation status. Panel C evaluates the statistical significance of the difference in a triple Dif-in-Dif regression.

The table reveals a pattern consistent with sanctuary status operating as a substitute for marriage as insurance prior to the treatment period. In three columns, during the pre-

¹⁶For the exercise, the sample retains never-sanctuary jurisdictions as the non-sanctuary status across all years. For jurisdictions eventually declared sanctuaries, observations are included only from the year in which the jurisdiction formally adopted sanctuary status, ensuring that pre-treatment comparison for each group is not contaminated by years in which treated units were not yet under sanctuary policies.

treatment years, sanctuary jurisdictions exhibit lower overall marriage transition rates (pre-treatment mean of 0.236, versus 0.268 in non-sanctuary areas for the full sample). Also, the marriage propensity of binational couples relative to non-binational couples is comparatively weaker within sanctuary areas than in non-sanctuary jurisdictions (a 2.0 p.p. against 4.2 p.p in the full sample). This stronger premium for binational couples in non-sanctuary cities probably was reflecting the higher marginal value of marriage as a protective device in the absence of local enforcement shields.

Post treatment period, the effect is heterogeneous across cohabitation status. The triple difference-in-differences coefficient is positive but not statistically significant for the entire sample (0.019 p.p, sd = 0.016) and for newly formed households (0.011 p.p, sd = 0.032). These estimates indicate that there is no robust differential response by sanctuary status in these groups. The effect concentrates among already-cohabiting couples, for whom the triple interaction is positive and statistically significant (0.042 p.p and sd = 0.020). These couples respond more strongly in sanctuary areas with a relative increase of around 20 percent over the pre-treatment mean (0.042/0.2083).

The event-study estimates further reveal that the divergence between sanctuary and non-sanctuary trajectories does not materialize in 2016 but emerges steadily from 2017 onward, with the two groups separating progressively through the end of the sample period (Figure A.7 in the Appendix). The sanctuary differential appears tied to the actual policy actions of the new administration rather than to the earlier anticipatory responses.

These patterns are consistent with a dual mechanism operating through sanctuary status. Before 2017, sanctuary policies reduced effective deportation risk by limiting local cooperation with federal immigration authorities, lowering the marginal value of marriage as a protective device. Upon taking office, the Trump administration explicitly threatened sanctuary jurisdictions, trying to signal that local protections could not be treated as durable. This shift may have been compounded by the broadening of interior enforcement priorities¹⁷,

¹⁷Whereas earlier enforcement had focused primarily on individuals with criminal convictions, post-2017

raising perceived deportation risk among the broader population.

Even when the results are consistent with a generalized response to the threat to protection guarantees in sanctuary cities after 2017, we cannot rule out alternative explanations for a higher increase in those areas. Unfortunately, there are no systematic public data on policy enforcement at such a granular level that allow us to test whether interior control enforcement is hit differently by sanctuary status in the first Trump administration.

8.2. Electoral signal and anticipatory effects

The fact that we observe effects already in 2016 in the event study specification—prior to President Trump taking office and therefore before the formal resurgence of enforcement—is suggestive of a response to changes in immigration policy expectations and rhetoric. To shed further light on these anticipatory effects, we constructed a measure of local exposure to anti-immigrant rhetoric using Donald Trump’s support in the 2016 presidential primaries at the PUMA level.

The use of primary election results has a key advantage: these elections took place between February and June 2016, prior to any formal enforcement measures implemented after the inauguration in January 2017. As such, they capture variation in political signaling and expectations rather than realized enforcement.

Districts in which Trump won the primaries by larger margins likely experienced a stronger local shock in terms of anti-immigrant rhetoric and perceived deportation risk. If households are susceptible to changes in expected risk, the effect should be stronger in areas where Trump’s electoral performance—and therefore the credibility of his immigration proposals—was higher.

Electoral data were compiled and harmonized using county-level results provided by the Bucknell University Election Data Center ([Bucknell University, 2017](#)). In states where county-level data were incomplete or unavailable, we supplemented the information using

guidelines expanded the scope to include those charged but not convicted and individuals deemed by ICE agents to pose a potential risk

the 2016 U.S. Election dataset on GitHub ([Hamner, 2017](#)).¹⁸ Data at the PUMA level was constructed taking PUMA-County equivalence employing geographical crosswalks. Due to the caucus election format or reporting at a geographic level other than the county, we have valid election data for 40 States.¹⁹

We consider multiple measures of electoral performance, each potentially capturing a distinct dimension of the perceived risks. First, we use the *share of votes* obtained by Trump in the district. Second, we use his *vote margin* over the runner-up candidate (when he won) or the margin relative to the leading candidate (when he did not). For both measures, we distinguish between performance relative to all candidates and performance within the Republican primary field.

We interpret Trump’s total vote share (relative to all candidates) as a proxy for the overall pro-Trump climate in the local environment, primarily indicative of the intensity of local political support and the salience of immigration discourse. The vote share within the Republican primary field instead captures ideological alignment among Republican voters in the district with Trump’s proposals.

The vote margin, in contrast, is adequate to capture electoral competitiveness and thus the credibility of Trump’s candidacy. A larger margin relative to competitors provides a clearer signal that Trump’s policy proposals were not merely rhetorical but increasingly likely to translate into federal policy. In this sense, the vote margin may more directly proxy for the perceived probability of policy implementation rather than for local ideological climate alone.

To test whether we verified anticipatory effects in this setting, we define 2016 as the sole

¹⁸When both sources were available, we relied on the Bucknell data, as it is based on finalized (certified) results from state election boards.

¹⁹By using the second data source, we were able to recover election results for Hawaii, Iowa, Louisiana, Utah and Virginia. Data is missing for Alaska, Colorado, District of Columbia, Kansas, Maine, Massachusetts, Minnesota, North Dakota, Rhode Island, Vermont and Wyoming. Data is not available for North Dakota and Wyoming due to the inability to find complete results for these states. Kansas and Minnesota report election outcomes at the Congressional District level. Massachusetts, Rhode Island and Vermont report at the town level. Alaska reports data at the State House District. Colorado and Maine report at the county level, but both are caucus elections and are not available in any of the sources.

post-treatment year in this specification. Including subsequent years would risk conflating changes in expectations with differences in actual enforcement intensity across states after 2017. In addition, we restrict the sample to couples in the retrospective pseudo-panel who in 2016 report residing in the same PUMA as one year prior, mitigating potential bias from endogenous migration responses.

In addition to the full set of individual, household, and macroeconomic controls used in the baseline specification, we control for initial immigrant composition at the PUMA level (including undocumented and targeted shares) interacted with the coefficient of interest, to account for systematic differences across more Trump-supportive districts. We also control for pre-treatment level of enforcement during the Secure Communities roll out.

The results from the triple interaction between Binational, Post, and Trump’s electoral performance are reported in the Appendix in Table A.9 for the margin of vote, relative to all candidates (Panel A) and relative to the Republican party (Panel B), using the one-year pseudo-panel sample.²⁰ All electoral measures are standardized. For greater transparency, results are reported for both sources separately: the Bucknell University dataset alone and the combined source, which recovers states missing from the former

The interaction with Trump’s vote margin relative to all candidates in the field displays the expected positive sign of 1.0 p.p. and 1.1 p.p, depending on the electoral source considered, although it does not reach conventional levels of statistical significance in the full sample (Panel A). When the margin is analyzed relative to the Republican competitors (Panel B), it yields a positive coefficient of 1.4 p.p with both sources and is statistically significant at 10% level for the Bucknell source ($sd=0.0073$) and 5% level ($sd=0.0070$) for the combined dataset. This is interpreted as an increase of one standard deviation in Trump’s primary vote margin, increasing in 2016 the probability of marriage among binational couples by 1.4

²⁰Because the post-treatment period is limited to 2016, cross-sectional samples suffer from limited statistical power for binational couples estimation. On the other hand, because migration is measured relative to the previous year, to ensure that the couple was already residing in the electoral area, we need to restrict to the one-year pseudo panel.

p.p., in addition to the baseline effect (measured at the mean value of the vote margin).

Columns (2)-(3) look at the heterogeneity by the presence of children in the household, for whom the cost of the potential enforcement policy would be higher (salient cost of family separation).²¹ In Panel B, the estimated effect of electoral competitiveness is larger in both cases (1.7 p.p and 1.8 p.p) and statistically significant for couples with children under age 16. For the column reporting no child at home, the estimate is small and negative and statistically indistinguishable from zero. In Panel A, margin relative to all candidates, the estimates now become significant and larger in magnitude for both data sources (2.3 p.p and 2.4 p.p). This is consistent with couples potentially facing the higher cost, internalizing the signals, and responding by protecting through union formalization at the highest rates.

Appendix Table A.10 reports results using performance measured as the vote share relative to all candidates and the Republican Party. Although coefficients are generally positive, none of them are statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels, when considering this measure of primary electoral outcome.

This is suggestive that immigrants seem to place greater weight on Trump’s electoral competitiveness than on the intensity of local political support. In particular, binational couples seem to have reacted more to the signal of Trump running in national elections as the chosen Republican Party candidate, rather than to the local level of competitiveness against the Democratic Party (margin over the total votes). If a strong national-intraparty alignment is expected when the time of the final election arrives, this would rationalize the voter’s distinction between the two signals. Instead, families with potentially higher costs interpreted both signals as informative of expected risk and reacted more strongly than the average.

Taken together, these findings suggest that the local anti-immigrant climate per se is

²¹We focus on the presence of children as the dimension of heterogeneity in this setting because unauthorized status, targeted nationality, and educational level may be correlated with location decisions. Conditional on residing in a given PUMA, the presence of a child in the household is less plausibly related to residential sorting

not sufficient to trigger marriage formalization. Living in a more Trump-supportive area, independent of the broader electoral viability of the candidate, does not systematically increase marriage transitions. Instead, what appears to matter is the perceived probability that Trump would run for and prevail in the presidential election, being able to implement his immigration agenda at the federal level. Thus, binational couples residing in areas where the electoral signal was stronger or maybe more surprising, responded more intensively, formalizing their unions in anticipation of heightened deportation risk.

9. Conclusions

This paper examines whether couples respond to heightened immigration-related uncertainty by transitioning into marriage. We exploit variation in couple composition to identify differential exposure to the shift in immigration policy expectations during the 2016 U.S. presidential campaign and the subsequent tightening of enforcement in 2017.

Using American Community Survey data from 2008 to 2019, we identify cohabiting binational couples—defined as unions between a U.S. citizen and a noncitizen partner—and compare their marriage transitions to those of citizen–citizen couples before and after 2016 in a difference-in-differences and event-study framework. To increase statistical power, we complement the cross-sectional analysis with a short retrospective pseudo-panel constructed from reported year of marriage and naturalization.

We find that binational couples respond to heightened uncertainty by transitioning into marriage at higher rates. The estimated effect ranges from 1.5 to 1.8 percentage points, corresponding to an 8–10 percent increase relative to pre-shock marriage rates. Our results are consistent across the different panels, robust to a wide range of controls, and are not explained by the potential eligibility of binational couples into the DACA program. Event-study estimates show no evidence of differential pre-trends and indicate that the response begins in 2016, prior to the formal reinstatement of Secure Communities.

The effect is concentrated among already-cohabiting couples with long-established ties to

the US — particularly those with ten or more years of residence — consistent with marriage serving as insurance for immigrants with the most to lose from deportation. The heterogeneity analysis, in turn, reveals that the effect is more pronounced among likely unauthorized immigrants, lower- and middle-educated households, individuals of nationalities prominently targeted in political rhetoric, and households with the presence of a child 16 years old or younger.

We do not find systematic differences between sanctuary and non-sanctuary jurisdictions, and in fact, we do observe an increase in marriage rates for cohabiting couples in sanctuary-declared areas. Instead, we find evidence of higher marriage rates in districts where Trump had better performance in the 2016 primary election. In particular, increasing the margin of votes over the runner-up and decreasing it with respect to the leading candidate, has a positive effect on couples responses. These patterns suggest that shifts in policy expectations during the campaign period played a central role, with subsequent enforcement dynamics reinforcing the initial response.

This paper contributes to the literature by documenting the legal formalization of unions as a strategic reaction to shift in policy uncertainty and migration enforcement. The results highlight the importance of strategic and behavioral responses not only to policy targeted programs but also to the shift in expectations and perceived risk. When state institutions are perceived as sources of uncertainty rather than protection, individuals may respond by seeking alternative forms of institutional security. In this sense, marriage becomes a means of safeguarding long-term investments in joint life projects: family formation, employment trajectories, and shared residency.

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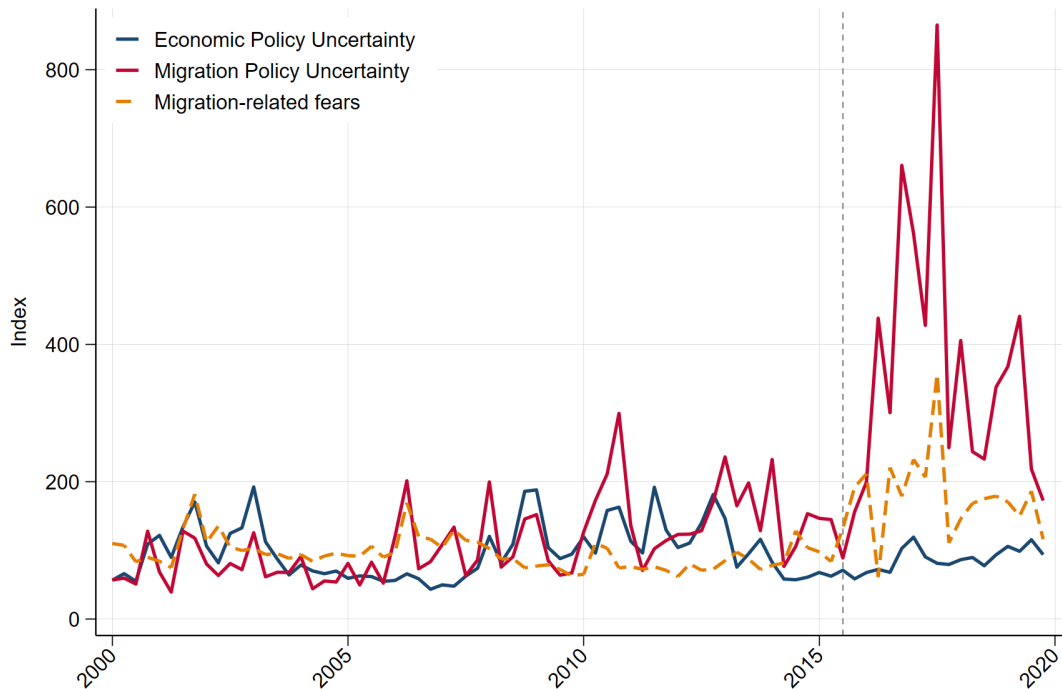
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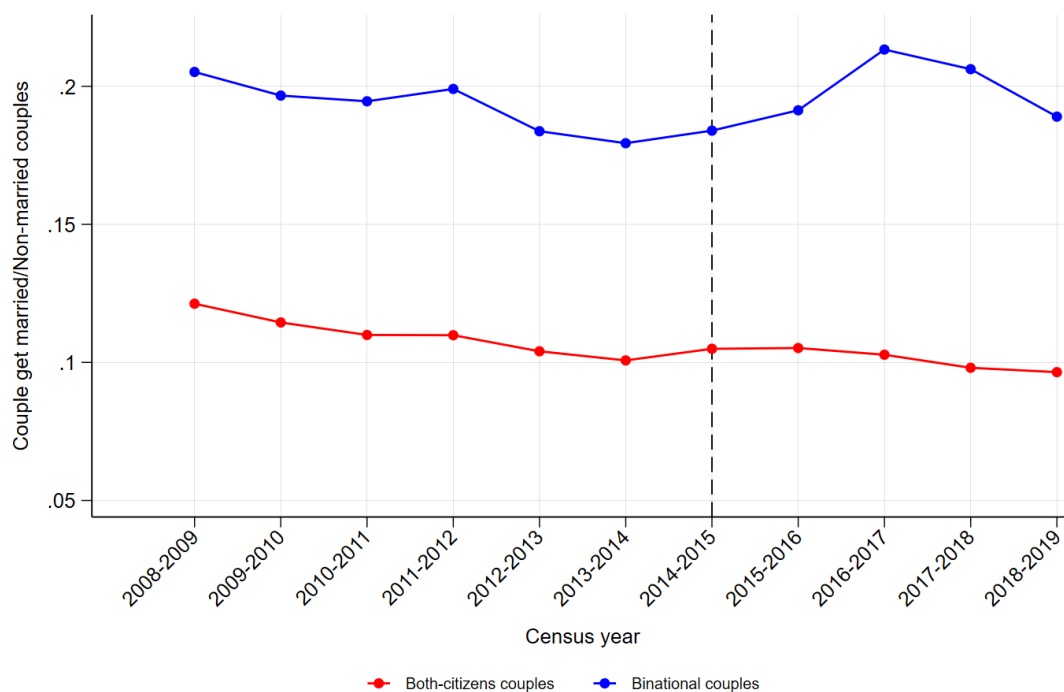
A. Appendix

Figure A.1: Evolution of Migration Policy Uncertainty and Migration-related fears in the US.



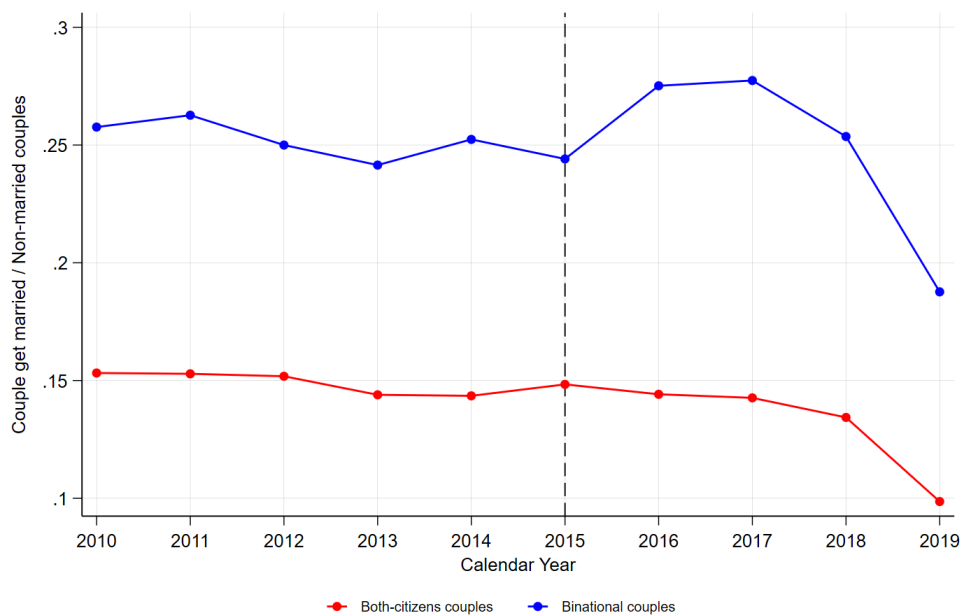
Notes: The figure plots quarterly Economic Policy Uncertainty (EPU), Migration Policy Uncertainty Index and Migration-related Fears Index for the United States. The EPU index captures policy uncertainty related to the overall economy, while the latter two captures policy uncertainty and levels of concern specifically related to migration, respectively. The index is constructed by counting newspaper articles with related terms set for each category. For further methodological details about the construction of the index see EPU website. The first vertical line corresponds to the Q3 of 2015, after Trump candidacy announcement. Source: Own author calculation based on EPU data.

Figure A.2: Evolution of Marriage Rates by Couple Type. Sample based on cross section data.

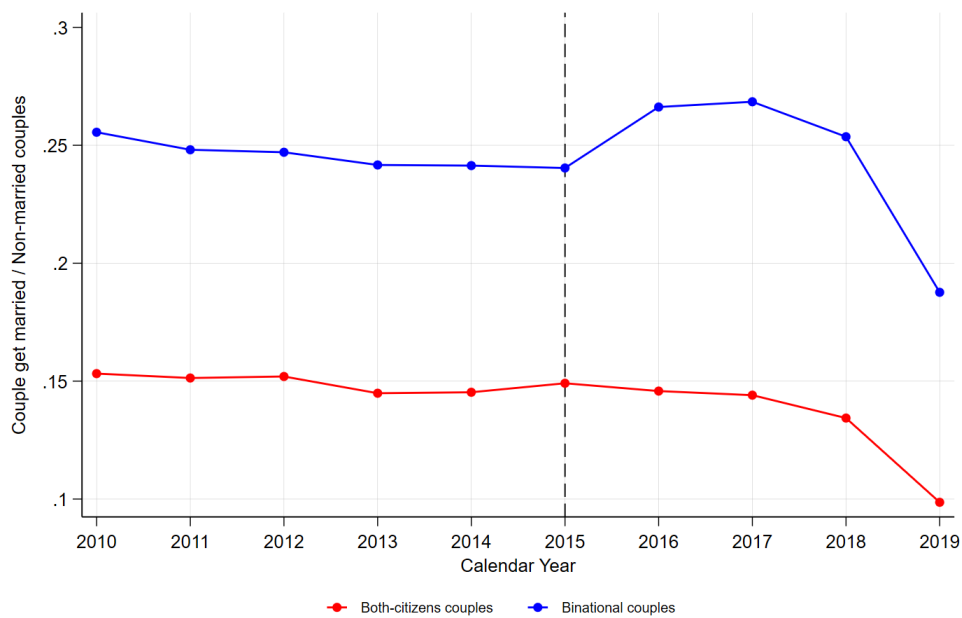


Notes: The figure displays average marriage transition rates by couple type using cross-sectional data. Two-year averages are reported to smooth year-to-year variation given small sample size for binational couple in a given year. Source: Own author calculation based on ACS data

Figure A.3: Evolution of Marriage Rates by Couple Type. Pseudo-panel samples.



(a) Panel window: 1 year



(b) Panel window: 2 years

Notes: The figure displays average marriage transition rates by couple type using the pseudo-panel sample constructed from retrospective ACS information. Source: Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Table A.5: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage Transitions. One-year and two-year Pseudo-panel Samples.

	Get Married				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
<i>Panel A: One-year Pseudo-panel Sample</i>					
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0185*** (0.0029)	0.0113*** (0.0026)	0.0110*** (0.0026)	0.0146*** (0.0027)	0.0159*** (0.0028)
Observations (000s)	148757.1	148757.1	148757.1	148757.1	148757.1
R-squared	0.012	0.373	0.373	0.373	0.373
Treated mean (Pre)	0.256	0.256	0.256	0.256	0.256
<i>Panel B: Two-year Pseudo-panel Sample</i>					
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0217*** (0.0022)	0.0162*** (0.0020)	0.0158*** (0.0019)	0.0186*** (0.0022)	0.0197*** (0.0022)
Observations (000s)	235078.8	235078.8	235078.8	235078.8	235078.8
R-squared	0.010	0.294	0.294	0.294	0.294
Treated mean (Pre)	0.248	0.248	0.248	0.248	0.248
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	NO	YES	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	NO	NO	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	NO	NO	NO	YES	YES
Undocument controls	NO	NO	NO	NO	YES

Notes: The table reports difference-in-differences estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to one if a cohabiting unmarried couple transitions into marriage in a given calendar year. Column (1) includes state and year fixed effects only. Column (2) adds individual and couple-level controls. Column (3) further incorporates state-level macroeconomic controls. Column (4) adds DACA eligibility interactions with year indicators. Column (5) controls for likely unauthorized immigrant status following Borjas (2017). Panel A uses a one-year pseudo-panel sample; Panel B uses a two-year pseudo-panel sample. The pre-treatment mean corresponds to the average marriage transition rate among binational couples before the treatment period. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

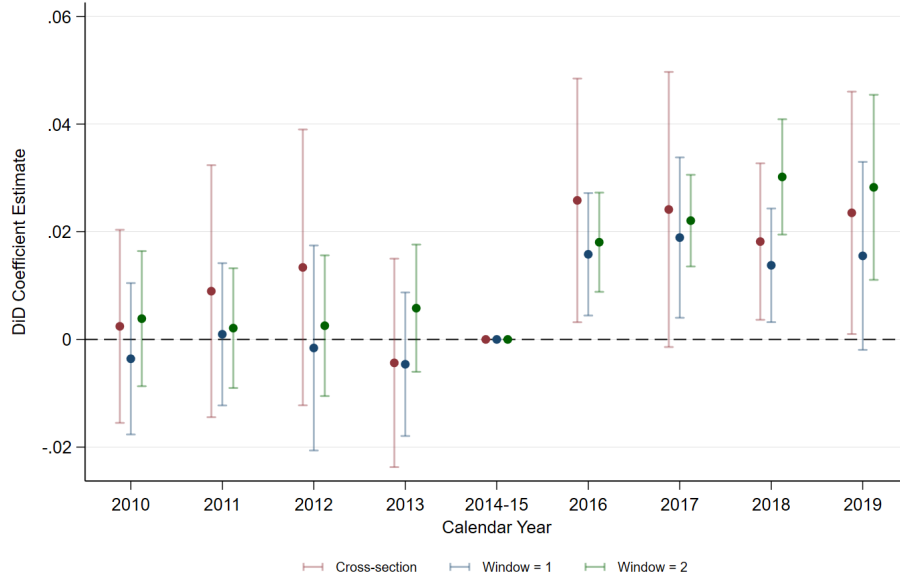
Table A.6: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage Transitions. Cross section sample. Post period starting 2017.

	Get Married				
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0191*** (0.0049)	0.0139*** (0.0030)	0.0138*** (0.0032)	0.0169*** (0.0041)	0.0180*** (0.0041)
Observations (000s)	69390.7	69390.7	69390.7	69390.7	69390.7
R-squared	0.011	0.383	0.383	0.383	0.383
Treated mean (Pre)	0.186	0.186	0.186	0.186	0.186
State FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	NO	YES	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	NO	NO	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	NO	NO	NO	YES	YES
Undocument controls	NO	NO	NO	NO	YES

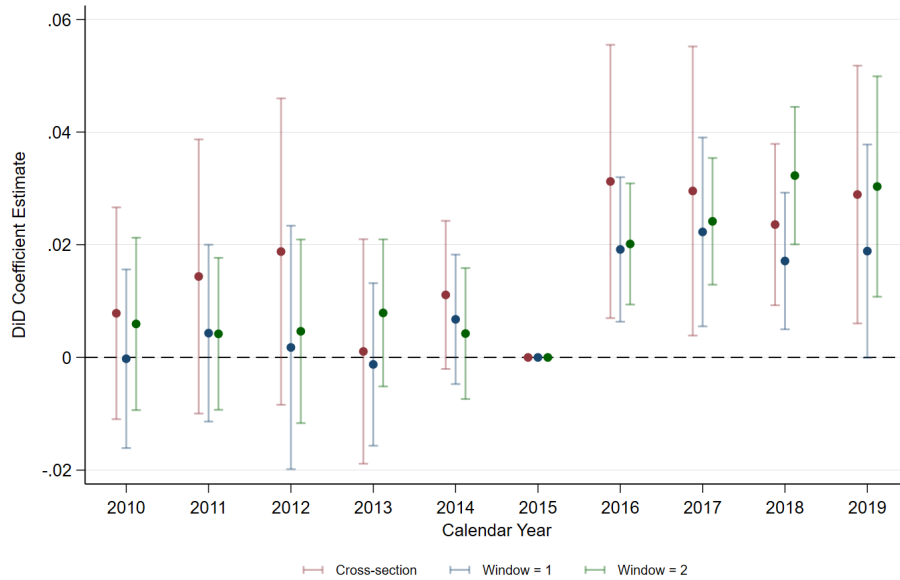
Notes: The table reports difference-in-differences estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to one if a cohabiting unmarried couple transitions into marriage in a given calendar year. The table replicates Table 2 but defines the post period from 2017 onward. To avoid conflating the anticipatory effects of 2016 with the pre-treatment period, 2016 is omitted. The pre-treatment mean corresponds to the average marriage transition rate among binational couples before the treatment period. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Figure A.4: Effect of Increase in Immigration-Related Uncertainty on Marriages. Event Study Estimates. Cross-section and Pseudo-panel Samples.

(a) Reference period: pooled 2014–2015

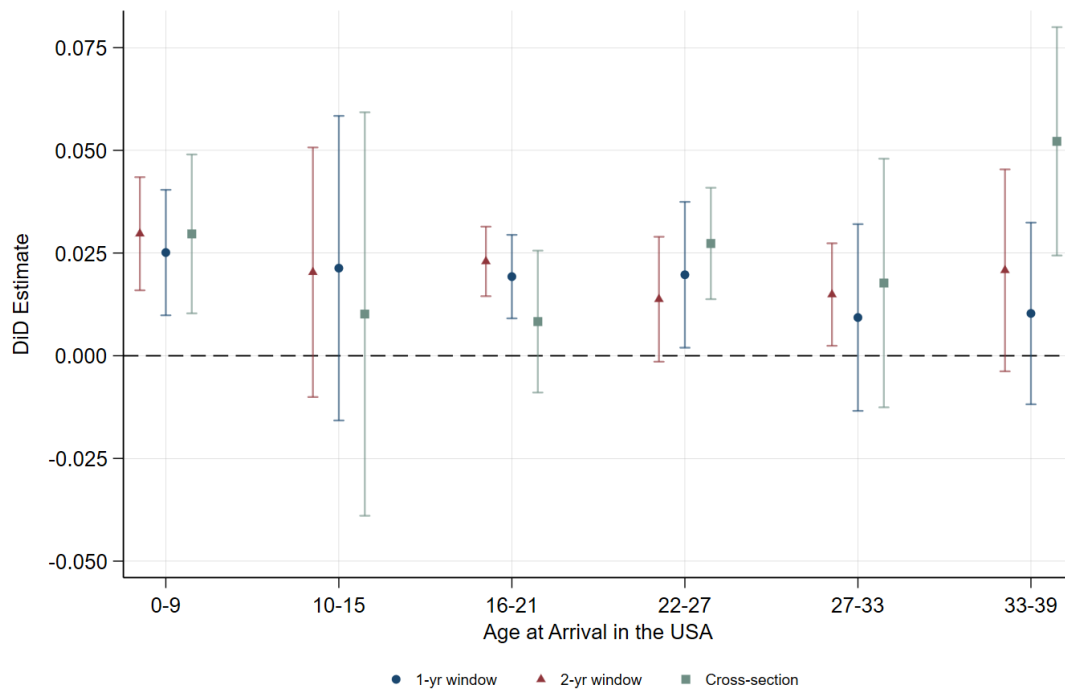


(b) Reference period: 2015



Notes: The figure reports event-study coefficients from equation (2), estimating the differential change in marriage transitions for binational couples relative to homogeneous citizen couples. Panel (a) uses the pooled 2014–2015 as the omitted category; Panel (b) uses 2015 as the omitted category. Both specifications include the full set of controls, state and year fixed effects, and enforcement terms interacted with year indicators for the pre-period. Bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. Estimates are presented for each sample. The pseudo-panel data are reconstructed from retrospective ACS information. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Figure A.5: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage Transitions by non-citizen's age at arrival to the US.



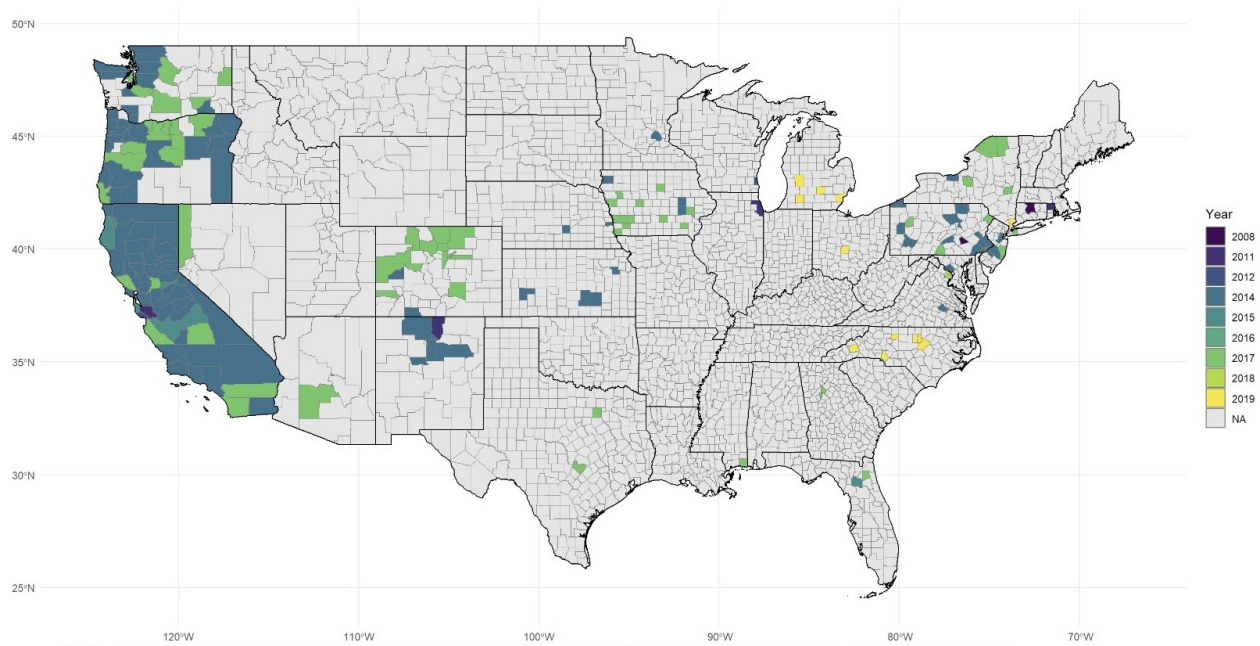
Notes: The figure reports estimates of the effect of immigration-related uncertainty on marriage transitions for binational couples. Each point is a separate estimate on the subsample of non-binational and binational couples where the immigrant member falls within that age-at-arrival block. Age at arrival is approximated as current age minus years since migration. Sample is restricted to already-cohabiting couples. Bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the state level. Pseudo-panel data are reconstructed from retrospective ACS information. Source: Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Table A.7: Heterogeneous Effects by Household Profile. Two-Year Pseudo-Panel sample.

	Authorization Status		Targeted Status		Education Level		Children under 16	
	Unauthorized	Authorized	Targeted	Non-Targeted	Low-Mid	High	Child <16	No Child <16
Binational $\times$ Post	—	—	0.0245*** (0.0031)	0.0081* (0.0041)	0.0212*** (0.0032)	0.0118*** (0.0036)	0.0229*** (0.0036)	0.0154*** (0.0032)
Mean Treated (Pre)	—	—	0.2342	0.2878	0.2223	0.3121	0.2332	0.2632
Observations (000s)	—	—	230061.8	221576.5	166959.4	68119.4	94005.8	141073.0
R-squared			0.293	0.292	0.266	0.346	0.298	0.295
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Macro Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
DACA Eligible	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Undocument Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES

Notes: The table replicates the heterogeneity analysis of Table 4 using the two-year retrospective pseudo-panel. Authorization status results are excluded as several classification criteria (occupation, government employment, public benefit receipt) cannot be reliably reconstructed two years prior to the survey. Targeted immigrants are defined based on country of birth, including Mexico, Latin America, Africa, Russia, and selected Middle Eastern countries, as described in the text. Low-mid education includes primary and secondary schooling, whereas high education refers to post-secondary attainment. Education level of the household head is considered. The presence of a child indicates at least one child 16 years old or younger living in the household. The estimates follow from the most complete specification detailed in Table 2. Standard errors are clustered at the state level.* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Figure A.6: Sanctuary Cities roll out. 2008-2019



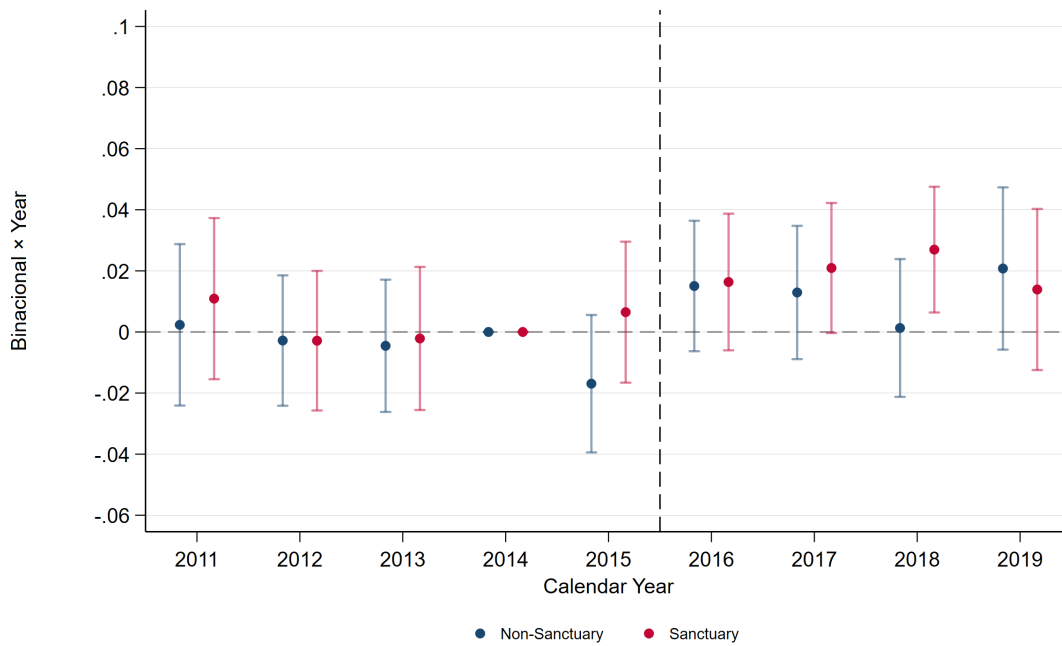
Notes: Sanctuary status through 2017 is drawn from [Alsan and Yang \(2024\)](#), based on ICE administrative records. This is complemented with information on jurisdictions adopting sanctuary policies between 2016 and 2019, using ICE reports through February 2017 and the ILRC counties list and mapping for the period 2017–2019. NA indicates counties for which no specific data are reported. *Source:* own elaboration based on [Alsan and Yang \(2024\)](#) and ILRC

Table A.8: Marriage Transitions by Sanctuary Status and Cohabitation Type. One-Year Pseudo-panel sample.

	Full Sample	Strict Cohabit.	New Household
Panel A: Non-Sanctuary			
Binational	0.042*** (0.0075)	0.034*** (0.0078)	0.088*** (0.0085)
Binational $\times$ Post	0.016*** (0.0044)	0.011* (0.0065)	0.015 (0.0107)
Mean Treated (Pre)	0.2680	0.2387	0.3218
Observations (000s)	105459.5	66714.5	15274.3
R-squared	0.361	0.348	0.331
Panel B: Sanctuary			
Binational	0.020* (0.0112)	0.007 (0.0143)	0.065** (0.0278)
Binational $\times$ Post	0.035** (0.0156)	0.054** (0.0190)	0.003 (0.0307)
Mean Treated (Pre)	0.2355	0.2083	0.2993
Observations (000s)	15956.6	10670.0	2115.8
R-squared	0.429	0.413	0.398
Panel C: Triple DiD			
Binational $\times$ Post	0.0162*** (0.0044)	0.013* (0.0064)	0.0146 (0.0107)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Sanctuary	0.019 (0.0157)	0.042** (0.0195)	0.011 (0.0324)
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	YES	YES	YES
Undoc. controls	YES	YES	YES

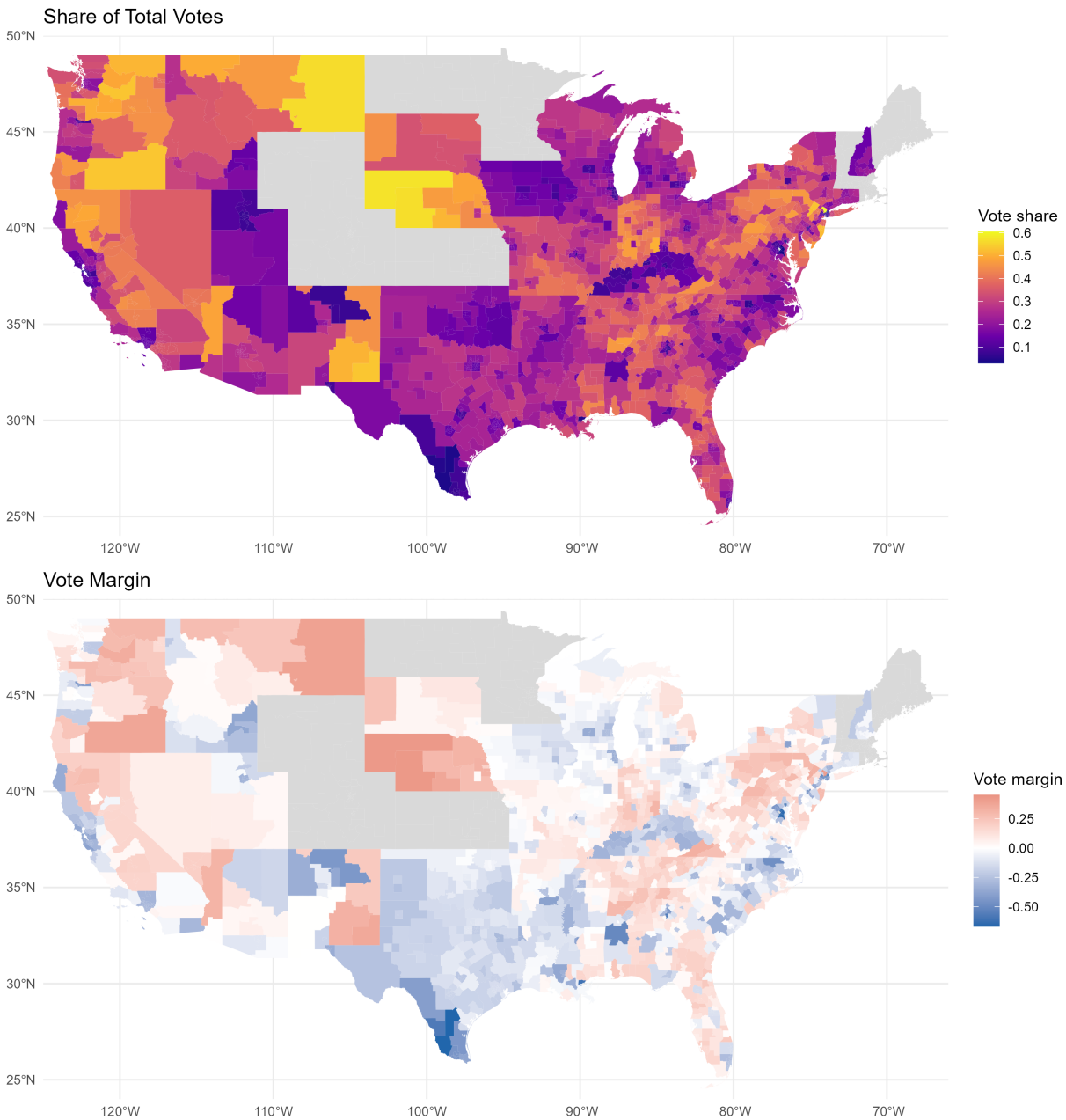
Notes: The table reports estimates for the one-year pseudo-panel sample. Panels A and B present separate difference-in-differences estimates for non-sanctuary and sanctuary jurisdictions, respectively. Panel C presents the triple difference-in-differences from a single fully saturated regression: all individual, household, macro, and immigrant-composition controls are interacted with the sanctuary indicator, and state and year fixed effects are absorbed separately for each sanctuary group. *Sanctuary* is defined as `Sanct_2015=1`, i.e., jurisdictions that had declared sanctuary status by end of 2015, prior to Trump’s campaign announcement. Jurisdictions declaring sanctuary status between 2016 and 2019 are excluded as potentially endogenous. Never-sanctuary jurisdictions are included in all years; treated jurisdictions are included only from the year of their sanctuary declaration onward, to avoid contaminating pre-trends. Strict cohabitation indicates the couple resided in the same dwelling the previous year; new household indicates couples not previously co-residing. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own calculations based on ACS data and sanctuary classification from [Alsan and Yang \(2024\)](#) and ILRC.

Figure A.7: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Marriage rates by sanctuary status.
One-Year Pseudo-panel sample.



Notes: Event study of the binational marriage response by sanctuary status, estimated separately for Non-Sanctuary (navy) and Sanctuary (red) PUMAs. Sanctuary status is fixed at 2015 — PUMAs that declared sanctuary between 2016 and 2019 are excluded to avoid contamination with potentially endogenous declarations triggered by Trump’s campaign. Base year is 2014. Coefficients correspond to the interaction $\text{Binational} \times \text{Year}$ from a regression including state fixed effects, individual controls, macroeconomic controls, DACA controls, undocumented share, and PUMA immigrant share. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. Sample: one-year window. *Source:* Own author calculation based on ACS data.

Figure A.8: Trump's electoral outcome in 2016 Primary Election by PUMA among all candidates.



Notes: Electoral data was sourced from Bucknell University Election Data Center and supplemented with the 2016 U.S. Election dataset on GitHub, for states where county-level data were incomplete or unavailable. Data at the PUMA level was constructed taking PUMA-County equivalence employing geographical crosswalks. Share of votes measures the percentage of votes obtained by Donald Trump in competition with the Republican candidates only. Margin of votes measures the difference in vote share over the runner-up Republican candidate (when he won) or the margin relative to the leading candidate (when he did not), computed within the Republican primary only. No election data available for Alaska, Colorado, District of Columbia, Kansas, Maine, Massachusetts, Minnesota, North Dakota, Rhode Island, Vermont, Wyoming. *Source:* Own author calculation based on Bucknell University Data Center and Hamner (2017).

Table A.9: Marriage Transitions and Margin of Votes, 2016 Primary Election. One-Year Pseudo-panel sample.

	Child Under 16		
	All	Yes	No
Panel A: Total Candidates			
Binational $\times$ Post	-0.010 (0.0115)	0.007 (0.0178)	-0.026* (0.0154)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [†]	0.010 (0.0086)	0.023** (0.0114)	-0.005 (0.0119)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [‡]	0.011 (0.0088)	0.024** (0.0118)	-0.006 (0.0121)
Panel B: Republican Party			
Binational $\times$ Post	-0.012 (0.0115)	0.003 (0.0177)	-0.026 (0.0157)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [†]	0.014* (0.0070)	0.018* (0.0093)	0.007 (0.0103)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [‡]	0.014** (0.0073)	0.017* (0.0094)	0.009 (0.0108)
Obs (000s)	56,636	23,027	33,609
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	YES	YES	YES
Undoc controls	YES	YES	YES
PUMA imm. share	YES	YES	YES

Notes: Electoral data was sourced from the Bucknell University Election Data Center and supplemented with the 2016 U.S. Election dataset from Hamner (2017), combining both sources to maximise coverage. Data at the PUMA level was constructed using PUMA-county geographical crosswalks. *Margin of votes* measures Trump's lead over the runner-up (or deficit relative to the leader): in Panel A, relative to all primary candidates; in Panel B, within the Republican primary only. States with no primary data available are excluded: Alaska, Colorado, DC, Kansas, Maine, Massachusetts, Minnesota, North Dakota, Rhode Island, Vermont, and Wyoming. Both measures are standardised. Post period is restricted to 2016 to isolate the expectations channel prior to the SC enforcement revival (2017). Standard errors are clustered at the PUMA level. [†] Combined source (Bucknell University Election Data Center and Hamner, 2017). [‡] Bucknell University Election Data Center only. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own calculations based on ACS data, Bucknell University Election Data Center, and Hamner (2017).

Table A.10: Marriage Transitions and Share of Votes, 2016 Primary Election. One-Year Pseudo-panel sample.

	Child Under 16		
	All	Yes	No
Panel A: Total Candidates			
Binational $\times$ Post	-0.010 (0.0115)	0.007 (0.0178)	-0.026* (0.0153)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [†]	0.008 (0.0089)	0.017 (0.0115)	-0.006 (0.0122)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [‡]	0.009 (0.0093)	0.017 (0.0122)	-0.005 (0.0126)
Panel B: Republican Party			
Binational $\times$ Post	-0.012 (0.0116)	0.004 (0.0177)	-0.025 (0.0157)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [†]	0.011 (0.0073)	0.015 (0.0096)	0.005 (0.0110)
Binational $\times$ Post $\times$ Trump Prim. Election [‡]	0.011 (0.0076)	0.014 (0.0099)	0.007 (0.0116)
Obs (000s)	56,636	23,027	33,609
State & Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Ind. & HH Controls	YES	YES	YES
Macro controls	YES	YES	YES
DACA controls	YES	YES	YES
Undoc controls	YES	YES	YES
PUMA imm. share	YES	YES	YES

Notes: Electoral data was sourced from the Bucknell University Election Data Center and supplemented with the 2016 U.S. Election dataset from Hamner (2017), combining both sources to maximise coverage. Data at the PUMA level was constructed using PUMA-county geographical crosswalks. *Share of votes* measures Trump's vote share: in Panel A, among all primary candidates; in Panel B, within the Republican primary only. States with no primary data available are excluded: Alaska, Colorado, DC, Kansas, Maine, Massachusetts, Minnesota, North Dakota, Rhode Island, Vermont, and Wyoming. Both measures are standardised. Post period is restricted to 2016 to isolate the expectations channel prior to the SC enforcement revival (2017). Standard errors are clustered at the PUMA level. [†] Combined source (Bucknell University Election Data Center and Hamner, 2017). [‡] Bucknell University Election Data Center only. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. *Source:* Own calculations based on ACS data, Bucknell University Election Data Center, and Hamner (2017).